



CITY: Pg 3

Delhi govt turns on the chill plan



NATION: Pg 5

BJP committed to women security: PM



FILM: Pg 12

KJo's 'Koffee with Karan' to return this year

Iran's FM returns to Pak amid uncertainty over 2nd round of talks

Trump says US, Iranian officials can talk by phone

ISLAMABAD: Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi arrived in Pakistan on Sunday for the second time in three days, as uncertainty persists over a planned second round of Iran-US talks. Local media reported that his latest visit comes shortly after he concluded meetings in Islamabad and travelled onward to Oman.

Araghchi landed at Nur Khan Airbase in Rawalpindi after a day-long trip to Oman, where he held discussions with Haitham bin Tariq on regional security and diplomatic efforts linked to tensions between Tehran and Washington. According to Pakistan's Dawn, he is expected to meet senior Pakistani officials before departing for Moscow.

While Pakistani authorities have not issued an official statement, reports by Geo News, citing diplomatic sources, confirmed the brief visit. Iran's state-run IRNA also noted his arrival in the early evening. Another Iranian outlet, ISNA, said Araghchi would convey Tehran's position on a framework aimed at ending the conflict.

The visit follows a shift in Washington's stance. Donald Trump announced he had cancelled a planned Islamabad trip by US envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner, citing internal disagreements within Iran's leadership. "We have all the cards, they have none," Trump wrote on Truth Social.

Trump on Sunday said the US and Iranian officials can talk by phone for a peace solution to the conflict. In an interview on Fox News Channel, Trump said he made that decision rather than send a delegation on a 17-hour flight.

"We have all the cards. If they want to talk, they can come to us, or they can call us," Trump said, not indicating when the call would take place. **Continued on P4**

Trump rushed out of dinner event after shots fired; 1 held

US Prez says suspect wrote about targeting of administration officials

ASSOCIATED PRESS/PTI

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump and other top officials were evacuated unharmed from the annual dinner of the White House Correspondents' Association after a man armed with multiple weapons fired shots outside the hotel ballroom.

The incident occurred on Saturday at around 8:34 PM when dinner was served. At that time, Trump was seen having a conversation with Weijia Jiang, the president of the association, and mentalist Oz Pearlman, who was scheduled to present a show at the marquee event at the Washington Hilton here.

Secret Service officials and other security personnel covered the President, First Lady Melania Trump, Vice President J D Vance, and the Second Lady Usha Vance, who were seated at the head table, and escorted them out of the ballroom.

Several guests at the dinner, including leaders across the political spectrum, journalists and other invitees, ducked under the table, apparently as a reflex reaction.

"The First Lady, plus the Vice President, and all Cabinet members, are in perfect condition," Trump posted on social media soon after the incident.

Putting up a brave face, Trump also announced on Truth Social



Members of law enforcement control shooting suspect Cole Tomas Allen during the White House Correspondents Dinner, Saturday

AP/PTI

that the dinner would be rescheduled within 30 days.

Hours later, Trump addressed a press conference at the White House and announced that the security personnel had captured one person who hails from California.

"I heard a noise and sort of thought it was a tray going down. I've heard that many times. It was a pretty loud noise, and it was from quite far away. He (the attacker) hadn't reached the area at all. They really got him," Trump told reporters, recalling the incident.

KEY POINTS

- » Incident occurred around 8:34 PM at Washington Hilton during dinner service.
- » Melania Trump, JD Vance, and Usha Vance escorted out safely.
- » Secret Service shielded top officials seated at head table.
- » Guests, journalists, politicians ducked under tables amid panic.
- » Trump later confirmed all officials "in perfect condition."



Trump said one security officer was shot at but saved as he was wearing a bulletproof vest.

In an interview on Fox News Channel on Sunday, Trump said the man accused of trying to storm the ballroom at the White House **Continued on P4**

Light rains and strong winds from Apr 28 likely

May bring brief respite to North



MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Northern India remained in the grip of an intense heatwave on Sunday, with temperatures nearing or crossing 45 degrees Celsius across several states, while weather officials signalled limited relief later this week due to an approaching western disturbance.

According to the India Meteorological Department, extreme heat conditions are likely to persist over the next couple of days. Authorities have advised residents to limit outdoor exposure, particularly during peak afternoon hours, as hot and dry winds continue to sweep across large parts of the country.

The soaring temperatures have also driven electricity consumption to unprecedented levels. Data from the power ministry showed that India's peak power demand touched a record 256.11 gigawatts on Saturday. This surpassed the previous high of 252.07 gigawatts recorded just a day earlier, reflecting the sharp increase in usage of cooling appliances such as air conditioners and desert coolers. **Continued on P4**

CLOSER LOOK

- » India Meteorological Department warns hot conditions to persist for two more days
- » Relief likely from April 28 due to western disturbance bringing rain and thunderstorms
- » India's peak power demand hits record 256.11 GW amid surge in cooling usage
- » Yellow alert issued in Delhi; temperatures may reach 44°C on Monday

AAP submits petition to Rajya Sabha Chairman seeking termination of 7 'defector' MPs

ANVI GUPTA

NEW DELHI: The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on Sunday said it has submitted a petition to the Rajya Sabha Chairman and Vice President C P Radhakrishnan seeking the disqualification of seven Members of Parliament who allegedly left the party and merged with the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), invoking provisions of the anti-defection law under the Tenth Schedule of the Constitution. Addressing a press conference at the party headquarters, AAP Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Singh said the move followed consultations with constitutional experts and senior advocates, including Kapil Sibal and P D T Achary, who, he claimed, were of the view that the membership of the seven MPs who left AAP would be "bound to be terminated." He said the party has requested the Chairman to hear the matter at the earliest and deliver a "just decision" in accordance with constitutional provisions.

Singh alleged that the MPs' decision to leave the party amounted to a

TAKEAWAYS

- » AAP alleges violation of anti-defection law and Tenth Schedule
- » Party warns of legal action if disqualification plea is delayed or rejected
- » Seven MPs quit AAP and merged with BJP on Friday

"betrayal" not only of AAP but also of the people of Punjab, democracy and the Constitution. He further accused the BJP of encouraging defections through the alleged misuse of central investigative agencies such as the Enforcement Directorate (ED) and the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), claiming that opposition leaders were first pressured and later inducted into the ruling party. Singh added that if elected representatives disagreed with their party's ideology, they should resign before switching sides, rather than continuing in office after being elected with the support of party legislators. **Continued on P4**

Court can reject anticipatory bail but cannot direct accused to surrender: SC

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: A court can reject anticipatory bail of an accused but it has no jurisdiction to direct him to surrender before the trial court, the Supreme Court has said.

A bench of Justices J B Pardiwala and Ujjal Bhuyan made the observation while hearing a plea filed by a man accused of cheating and forgery.

"If the court wants to reject the anticipatory bail, it may do so, but the court has no jurisdiction to say that the petitioner should now surrender," the bench said.

The Jharkhand High Court had rejected anticipatory bail plea of the accused and asked him to surrender and seek regular bail.

In this case, a complaint had been filed before a magistrate alleging offences under Sections 323 (voluntarily causing hurt), 420 (cheating), 467 (forgery of valuable security), 468 (forgery for purpose of cheating), 471 (using forged document) and 120B read with 34 of the IPC, in connection with a land dispute.

The high court had dismissed the second anticipatory bail application of the accused on the ground that no new circumstances were shown.

It had relied on its earlier order rejecting his first anticipatory bail plea, in which the court directed the petitioner to **Continued on P4**



He framed a changing nation, ONE MOMENT AT A TIME

Renowned photojournalist Raghu Rai passes away at 83



MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Renowned photojournalist Raghu Rai, whose images chronicled the country's social, political and cultural evolution over more than five decades, died at a private hospital early Sunday. He was 83. Widely regarded as one of India's most influential visual storytellers, Rai leaves behind a body of work that shaped how generations have seen and understood the nation.

His son, photographer Nitin Rai, said Rai had battled cancer over the past two years. "Dad was diagnosed with prostate cancer two years ago but he was cured. Then it spread to the stomach, that too was cured. Recently, the cancer spread to his brain and then there were age-related issues too," he said. Rai is survived by his wife Gurmeet, son Nitin, and daughters Lagan, Avani and Purvai.

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Passed away in Delhi after cancer-related complications; survived by wife and three children
- » Career spanned nearly 60 years; began at The Statesman in 1966
- » Protégé of Henri Cartier-Bresson; joined Magnum Photos in 1977
- » Documented defining moments: Bangladesh refugee crisis (1972), Bhopal gas tragedy (1984)



» His Bhopal image of a deceased infant became globally recognised

» Captured powerful portraits of figures like Indira Gandhi,

Dalai Lama, Mother Teresa

» Known for photographing ordinary people with depth and sensitivity; turned everyday scenes into lasting visual records

Born on December 18, 1942, in Jhang in undivided Punjab, now in Pakistan, Rai trained as a civil engineer before turning to photography at the age of 23. His professional journey began in 1966 when he joined The Statesman as chief photographer. What followed was a prolific career

spanning nearly six decades, during which his lens captured defining moments in India's modern history while also illuminating

Continued on P4



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FOUR SUFFER INJURIES

Swiss plane suffers engine problem, aborts takeoff; passengers evacuated

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A Zurich-bound Swiss International Air Lines' plane carrying 245 people aborted takeoff at the Delhi airport early morning on Sunday due to an engine issue, following which a full emergency was declared and passengers were evacuated, with four of them suffering injuries, according to the airline.

There were 232 passengers, including four infants, and 13 crew members onboard the A330-300 aircraft with registration HB-JHK that was to operate the flight LX147 when the incident took place around 1 am. Officials said that the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) would probe the incident.

AAIB investigates accidents as well as incidents that are classified as serious.

"Four passengers remain in the hospital... A cabin crew member sustained a sprained



ankle. The other crew members are unharmed," an airline spokesperson said in an updated statement and added that the one cabin crew member suffered a minor foot injury. Details about how the passengers suffered injuries could not be immediately ascertained.

Shortly after 1 am local time on April 26, an issue occurred with one of the engines during the takeoff of flight LX147 in Delhi. "The crew aborted the

takeoff and, after assessing the situation, decided as a precaution to evacuate the aircraft," the spokesperson said.

Sources said smoke was observed from the port side of the main wheel and initially, the input was that there was smoke from one of the landing gears. Delhi airport operator DIAL said the operations at the airport remained unaffected due to the incident involving the aircraft. In an earlier statement, the airline spokesper-

CLOSER LOOK

» There were 232 passengers, including four infants, 13 crew members onboard the A330-300 aircraft with registration HB-JHK that was to operate the flight LX147 when the incident took place around 1 am

» Officials said that the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) would probe the incident

Traffic Controller (ATC). After the checking was done by the airside team, it was confirmed that during the rejected takeoff, smoke was observed originating from the port side of the main wheel, they added.

Delhi airport operator DIAL said in the early hours of Sunday, a full emergency was declared for flight LX147 on Runway 28/10.

"All prescribed safety protocols were promptly executed, and passengers were safely evacuated. Airport operations remained unaffected," DIAL said in a post on X. The airline spokesperson said it was determined to fully understand what led to this incident, including what led to the engine problem.

Regretting the inconvenience caused, the spokesperson said, "We are aware that such an event can be stressful and traumatic for those affected. Our teams remain in close contact with our passengers."

Food delivery agent shot dead after altercation with 'cop'



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

NEW DELHI: A food delivery agent was shot dead at paint-bank range while his friend sustained injuries after the bullet passed through the victim's body and hit him during a late-night altercation with a Delhi Police "head constable" here.

The incident occurred in the early hours of Sunday, when the victim and his friend were standing on a road in Jaffarpur Kalan village and the accused, Neeraj, allegedly opened fire following an argument with them, police said in a statement.

The family of the deceased alleged that Neeraj is a head constable with the Delhi Police. Police, however, did not confirm this.

According to the police, information was received at Jaffarpur Kalan police station at around 2.30 am from a hospital regarding the admission of two persons with gunshot injuries, one of whom was declared brought dead. The deceased has been identified as Pandav Kumar (21), while his injured friend is Krishan.

Preliminary inquiry

revealed that the two had attended a birthday party of a two-year-old child at their friend's residence.

After the celebrations, the victims were engaged in a conversation with the hosts of the party on the road before leaving, it read.

Police said that Neeraj, who lives on the opposite side of the road, came down and got into an argument with them. During the altercation, he allegedly fired at Kumar, aiming at his chest from close range.

"The bullet pierced through Kumar's chest and exited his body before hitting Krishan, who was sitting pillion behind him on a motorcycle, in the right side of his abdomen," the statement said.

Both were immediately rushed to a nearby hospital, where Kumar was declared dead, while Krishan is undergoing treatment.

A case has been registered against the absconding accused, and efforts are on to nab him, the police said.

The deceased's family claimed that the firing was unprovoked and that the accused suddenly opened fire after a brief argument and immediately fled from the spot.

The mother of the deceased said, "I want justice for my son. He was innocent and had gone to attend a birthday party. He was working hard to support the family. The accused should be given strict punishment."

The family said that the shot was from very close range without any reason.

HC asks Delhi govt to explain why chairman and member posts vacant in minority panel since '23

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court has asked the city government to explain why vacancies in the posts of chairman and members in the Delhi State Minorities Commission have not been filled since 2023.

A bench of Chief Justice D K Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia observed that merely because the law stipulates that vacancies must be filled "as soon as may be", the posts cannot be "kept vacant perennially", and asked the



authorities to initiate the appointment process.

It also directed the Delhi government to file an affidavit disclosing the steps taken and the timeline within

It also directed the Delhi government to file an affidavit disclosing the steps taken

which the vacancies in the Commission would be filled.

The court passed the order on April 22 on a public interest litigation filed by Salek Chand Jain.

Police bust illegal arms network, 3 arrested

Supplier tracked to Meerut; police seize pistols, cartridges

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Anti-Narcotics Squad of the Delhi Police has busted an illegal arms supply network with the arrest of three accused, including a key supplier from Meerut, Uttar Pradesh.

Acting on a tip-off received by its east district team, the squad apprehended Babu alias Murdari and Raj Kumar, both residents of Ghazipur in Delhi, and Parvinder, a resident of Meerut.

According to police, the accused were intercepted on April 23 near the CRPF Red Light on the road connecting New Kondli Market and Khoda, following intelligence developed through social media monitoring and technical surveillance. Babu alias Murdari and Raj Kumar were



travelling in a car when they were detained. An illegal pistol with two live cartridges was recovered from Babu, while a button-actuated knife was seized from Raj Kumar. A case under the Arms Act was registered at Ghazipur Police Station, and both were taken into custody.

During interrogation, the duo revealed that they had

An illegal pistol with two live cartridges was recovered from Babu, while a button-actuated knife was seized from Raj Kumar

procured the weapons from a supplier identified as Parvinder. Acting on this information, police conducted a raid at a residence in Dadri, Uttar Pradesh, where they recovered an automatic pistol, two country-made pistols, and 14 live cartridges.

Following sustained efforts and technical surveillance, Parvinder was subse-

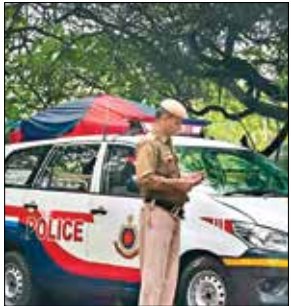
The petitioner's counsel stated that since August 24, 2023, no one has been occupying the posts of chairman and members in the Commission.

Issuing a notice to the Delhi government on the petition, the court said, "We call upon the respondent, GNCTD, to file an affidavit to be sworn by an appropriate officer, who shall not be below the rank of principal secretary/additional chief secretary, to explain as to why the vacancies in the Commission have not been filled in since 24.08.2023."

"The averments made in the writ petition are to the effect that neither any member nor the chairperson has been appointed in the Commission from 24.08.2023 till date, which is quite a long period.

"Merely because sub-section (5) of Section 4 of the Act states that vacancy shall be filled 'as soon as may be' by the government, will not mean that the vacancy can be kept vacant perennially," it observed.

The court listed the matter for further hearing on August 12.



Blaze engulfs factory & spreads to warehouses

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: A massive fire broke out at a plastic factory and warehouse in Gurugram's Bajghera area on Sunday and spread to nearby units, prompting evacuation of surrounding areas, officials said.

The blaze was discovered around 5 am, when factory workers noticed the fire and initially tried to douse it before alerting the fire brigade and police as the flames spread, they said.

Half a dozen fire tenders were rushed to the spot and brought the fire under control after nearly four hours of fire-fighting, according to officials.

Police evacuated the surrounding area as a precaution, while thick smoke from the blaze triggered panic in six nearby residential societies.

The fire also spread to two

Fire officer Narendra Kumar: 'No person or animal was trapped in the blaze'

wood warehouses located near the affected factory and warehouse.

Fire officials said the exact cause of the blaze is yet to be ascertained, though a short circuit or spark is suspected.

"Most of the factories in the area are scrap crushers where iron and plastic scrap is processed.

"The presence of plastic material made firefighting difficult, but the blaze was brought under control," a fire department official said.

Fire officer Narendra Kumar said no person or animal was trapped in the fire.

FEST VIOLENCE

Hans Raj College suspends 4 student union office bearers

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In the wake of reported violence and disciplinary breaches during the annual fest earlier this month, Hans Raj College has suspended four office bearers of its Students' Union for the 2025-26 term. The action follows recommendations by the college's Students' Welfare and Discipline Committee after reviewing incidents that took place on April 8 and 9.

According to an official notice the students enrolled across courses including English (Hons.), Physical Sciences, Commerce (Hons.), and Zoology have been placed under immediate suspension pending disciplinary proceedings. The administration has barred them from entering college premises during this period,

though they will be permitted to appear for examinations and internal assessments. The order clarified that the suspension is interim in nature and will remain in force until further directions are issued.

The move reflects a tightening stance by college authorities on campus conduct, particularly during large-scale events that draw significant student participation. While details of the specific incidents have not been publicly elaborated, the administration described them as involving "serious misconduct and breach of discipline."

Meanwhile, a separate development within the University of Delhi ecosystem has sparked debate among academic stakeholders. In a letter addressed to the Vice-Chancellor, members of the Delhi University Teachers' Associa-

tion (DUTA) have raised objections to the proposed renaming and relocation of Dyal Singh Evening College. The signatories argued that the decision, reportedly taken by the college's governing body, lacked adequate consultation with students, faculty, and staff.

The letter further highlighted concerns about the institutional and academic implications of relocating a college with over seven decades of legacy. Faculty members cautioned that such a move could disrupt its established academic environment and diminish its standing within Delhi's educational landscape.

Together, the two developments underscore ongoing tensions around governance, discipline, and institutional decision-making within Delhi University's colleges.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has arrested a 23-year-old man wanted in two robbery cases in Bihar involving amounts of over Rs 12 lakh, officials said on Sunday.

The accused, Roshan Kumar, a resident of Tikri Border in Delhi and a native of Aurangabad in Bihar, had been evading arrest and hiding in the national capital, they said.

The police said Kumar was wanted in a robbery case registered at Rafiganj in Aurangabad on October 15, last year, where he, along with his associates, allegedly robbed Rs 2.8 lakh from a man at gunpoint.

During interrogation, he also disclosed his involvement in another robbery case involving Rs 10 lakh, registered on January 12, in Aurangabad, a senior police officer said.

HIGHLIGHTS

» The police said Kumar was wanted in a robbery case registered at Rafiganj in Aurangabad on October 15, last year, where he, along with his associates, allegedly robbed Rs 2.8 lakh from a man at gunpoint

» During interrogation, he also disclosed his involve-



ment in another robbery case involving Rs 10 lakh, registered on January 12, in Aurangabad

Acting on a request from the Bihar Police, a team of the crime branch launched a coordinated operation and tracked down the accused. He was apprehended from the Tikri Border area on Saturday.

His associates in the earlier robbery case have already been arrested by the Bihar Police, the officer said.

During questioning, Kumar revealed that he was drawn into criminal activities due to poor financial conditions and in pursuit of easy money. He was previously involved in at least two criminal cases, including dacoity and attempt to murder, registered in Bihar in 2021, police said, adding that further investigation is underway.

Delhi Police step up 'Nasha – Not Cool' campaign with flash mobs, cycle rally

NEW DELHI: Continuing its week-long anti-drug awareness campaign, "Nasha – Not Cool", Delhi Police marked Day 3 with a series of public engagement activities, including flash mobs and a cycling event, aimed at promoting a drug-free and healthy lifestyle.

Anti-drug awareness flash mobs were organised at prominent locations such as Central Park in Connaught Place, Kartavya Path in the New Delhi district, and Select Citywalk Mall in Saket. The performances drew large weekend crowds and conveyed the harmful effects of substance abuse through lively and engaging acts, encouraging people to make healthier life choices. Similar events were also conducted

in the North-West, West and Dwarka districts.

An early morning cycling rally was also held in the New Delhi district, witnessing participation from around 400 people, including police personnel, youth, volunteers and members of the public. The rally began at Major Dhyan Chand National Stadium, passed through India Gate and surrounding areas, and concluded at the stadium.

The campaign has received support from personalities such as Anil Kapoor, Kamal Khan, Rani Rampal, Virender Sehgal, Zaheer Khan and Suresh Raina. Awareness efforts are also being carried out through street plays, radio jingles, social media, cinema halls and the Delhi Police Jansampark Vahan.

MPOST

Delhi govt turns on the chill plan

Cool roofs, misting bus stops, ORS & worker relief under Heat Wave Action Plan 2026

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: With yet another harsh summer descending on Delhi with temperatures soaring and heatwave conditions intensifying, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced special measures, including cool roofing, misting systems at bus stops, ORS support for school-children, relief for construction workers, and arrangements for animals and birds to reduce the impact of extreme heat.

Reviewing the Heat Wave Action Plan 2026, Gupta on Sunday directed officials to ensure strict implementation of the measures on the ground, saying the government's approach this year is more scientific and robust, with special focus on vulnerable groups and high-risk thermal hotspots identified across the city, according to an official statement.

She said if required, school-children may be given ORS solution before leaving school to prevent dehydration during their commute, while construction workers could be asked to halt outdoor work between 12 noon and 3 pm during severe heatwave conditions.

Workers will also be provided with drinking water, caps, and gamchas for protection



against the sun, while first-aid kits and ice packs will be kept available at worksites.

The chief minister also directed departments, including the Delhi Development Authority, the Education Department and the Delhi Jal Board, to ensure water and shade for animals and birds by installing water containers for birds and dedicated water points for stray animals across parks, bus depots and school campuses.

As part of long-term measures, the government is moving towards a "Cool Roof Policy

2026". Reflective coating has already been applied over nearly 28,674 sq ft at Kashmere Gate ISBT to reduce indoor temperatures, while high-pressure misting systems will be installed at bus stops, and anti-smog guns will be used to cool densely built-up areas.

Gupta noted that Delhi has been witnessing temperatures above 40 degrees Celsius for nearly 40 consecutive days over the past two to three years, making heatwave preparedness more critical.

She informed that the government conducted a scientific

assessment of the city using satellite data to identify high-risk zones. Ayanagar in south Delhi remains among the most sensitive areas, having recorded temperatures of 45.5 degrees Celsius earlier.

Najafgarh and Safdarjung have also witnessed extreme highs, while Wazirpur, Jahan-girpuri, Khayala, Shastri Park, Vishwas Nagar, Harkesh Nagar, Hari Nagar and Delhi Gate have emerged as thermal hotspots, according to the statement.

Densely populated fringe areas such as Sawda, Mubarakpur Dabas, Bhalswa, Nand

KEY POINTS

- » Reviewing the Heat Wave Action Plan 2026, CM Gupta directed officials to ensure strict implementation of the measures on the ground, saying the government's approach this year is more scientific and robust, with special focus on vulnerable groups and high-risk thermal hotspots identified across the city
- » She said if required, schoolchildren may be

- given ORS solution before leaving school to prevent dehydration during their commute, while construction workers could be asked to halt outdoor work between 12 noon and 3 pm during severe heatwave conditions
- » As part of long-term measures, the government is moving towards a 'Cool Roof Policy 2026'
- » Residents can seek help through the 24x7 helpline numbers 1077, 1070 and 112



Capital scorcher: 42.1 deg Celsius

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi recorded a maximum temperature of 42.1 degrees Celsius on Sunday, 3.1 notches above the seasonal average, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD).

The minimum temperature was recorded at 26.2 degrees Celsius, 2.4 notches above normal, at the Safdarjung observatory, the city's primary weather station.

The weather office said maximum temperatures between 42 and 44 degrees Celsius were recorded across the city, but heatwave conditions were not declared as the readings remained close to the prevailing normal levels.

"The normal temperature is updated every five days to reflect seasonal changes, and for Safdarjung it has increased to 39.0 degrees Celsius for April 26-30 from 37.7 degrees Celsius during April 21-25, which reduces the gap needed to classify a heatwave," the IMD said.

Among other monitoring stations, Palam recorded a maximum temperature of 41.8 degrees Celsius and a minimum of 27.4 degrees Celsius, while Lodhi Road registered 42.2 degrees Celsius and 24.6 degrees Celsius, respectively.

Ridge recorded the highest maximum temperature at 43.5 degrees Celsius, with a minimum of 26.5 degrees Celsius, while Ayanagar logged 43.1 degrees Celsius and 27.1 degrees Celsius, respectively.

The weather department has issued a yellow alert for heat-

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The minimum temperature was recorded at 26.2 degrees Celsius, 2.4 notches above normal, at the Safdarjung observatory, the city's primary weather station
- » Ridge recorded the highest maximum temperature at 43.5 degrees Celsius, with a minimum of 26.5 degrees Celsius, while Ayanagar logged 43.1 degrees Celsius and 27.1 degrees Celsius
- » The air quality was recorded in the 'poor' category at 4 pm, with an Air Quality Index (AQI) reading of 222

wave-like conditions in the city for Monday, with the maximum and minimum temperatures expected to reach around 44 degrees Celsius and 27 degrees Celsius, respectively.

Relative humidity was recorded at 23 per cent at 5.30 pm. The air quality was recorded in the 'poor' category at 4 pm, with an Air Quality Index (AQI) reading of 222, according to the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) data.

According to the CPCB, an AQI between zero and 50 is considered 'good', 51 to 100 'satisfactory', 101 to 200 'moderate', 201 to 300 'poor', 301 to 400 'very poor', and 401 to 500 'severe'.

City Briefs

POLICE: WOMAN THROWS 18-MONTH-OLD DAUGHTER IN DRAIN IN FARIDABAD

FARIDABAD: A woman allegedly killed her 18-month-old child — her sixth daughter — by throwing her into a drain in Faridabad, claiming she committed the crime as she was unable to take care of her family due to poverty, according to police. The incident occurred near Dheeraj Nagar on April 23 when the girl's body was found stuck in an iron mesh along a drain by two school children, the police said on Sunday, adding the body was retrieved and sent for a postmortem. A Crime Branch team, which was probing the case, found CCTV footage showing the girl's mother carrying her in her arms in the area. She then returned alone. The police took the woman into custody, and during questioning, she confessed to throwing the girl into the drain, they said. The infant died of drowning. The accused was identified as Neelam, a native of Madhubani in Bihar. She lived in Faridabad with her husband Sanjay, who works in a private firm, the police said. A senior investigating officer said that during interrogation, the woman said that the deceased was the youngest of her six daughters and that she was driven to commit the crime due to poverty. "She revealed that her family's financial situation was extremely poor, and with six daughters, she was unable to raise them properly," the officer said. Police spokesperson Yashpal said they are investigating the matter and the entire picture will be clear soon.

FTII EXAM AT A CENTRE IN DELHI CANCELLED

NEW DELHI: The Film and Television Institute of India (FTII) administration on Sunday cancelled its entrance examination at a centre in Delhi after a few students allegedly entered the strong room and manhandled the staff, official sources said. Exams at all other centres proceeded peacefully, they said. The matter will be investigated to identify the exact cause and chronology of events, the sources said on the cancellation. During the first shift of the FTII's entrance examination at the said centre in Delhi, a delay in paper distribution in one building led to a law and order issue. A few candidates allegedly entered the strong room and manhandled the staff, they said. In an emergency meeting with the examination agency and the centre incharge, the FTII administration decided to cancel the examination for candidates in that specific building, they said. Police were on site and the FTII observer was also present. During the second shift, the FTII observer noted the concerns raised by a few candidates and a decision was taken to cancel the second shift exam as well for the specific building, the sources said. A decision on the date of re-examination will be communicated to the candidates, a source said.

MAN ARRESTED FOR STABBING WIFE WITH SHARP OBJECT IN KHAJURI KHAS

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police on Sunday arrested a 35-year-old man for allegedly stabbing his wife, an advocate, with a sharp object in northeast Delhi's Khajuri Khas, an official said. The accused, Manoj Kumar, a resident of Sonia Vihar, was arrested from the Khajuri Khas area on Sunday, the officer said. The incident took place on April 22 when Kumar allegedly stabbed his 38-year-old wife in the Khajuri Khas, police said, adding that she was admitted at AIIMS, Delhi, for treatment. "During interrogation, Kumar confessed to the crime and told police that he attacked his wife following a family dispute," the officer said. Domestic discord is believed to be the motive behind the attack, though investigators are examining all angles, police said. Further verification revealed that the accused was previously involved in a case related to abduction and murder, police said.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A special session of the Delhi Assembly will be held on April 28 to discuss the women's reservation issue after related bills were defeated in the Lok Sabha by the Opposition.

The BJP has accused the Opposition of betraying women and several party-ruled states have called similar special Assembly sessions to discuss the issue.

A Delhi Assembly secretariat statement said that the Fifth Session of the Eighth Legislative Assembly is scheduled to commence on Tuesday at 11



AM in the Assembly Hall.

Officials said that the session was likely to be one-day-

long to take up the women's quota bill discussion, but it could be extended further if

Fire breaks out in Gr Noida slum, 8 huts gutted

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

NOIDA: A fire broke out in a cluster of shanties in the Chuharpur Khadar area of Greater Noida on Sunday, gutting eight huts, officials said.

No casualties have been reported so far in the incident that occurred under the Ecotech-1 police station area, they said.

Chief Fire Officer Pradeep Kumar said two fire tenders were rushed to the spot around 5 pm after information about the blaze was received.

"The fire team has successfully doused the blaze. Eight huts were destroyed in the fire, while approximately 25 to 30 shanties were saved. The fire was caused by sparks from an electrical pole," he said.

According to the officials, the flames spread rapidly, engulfing several huts within minutes.

Thick plumes of smoke and high flames were seen rising from the shanties from a distance, triggering panic in the surrounding area.

Everyone should come together in interest of nation, says CM Rekha

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

KATRA/JAMMU: "Everyone gains wisdom with time", Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta quipped on Sunday on multiple AAP MLAs switching to the BJP. Gupta was speaking to reporters before leaving for the shrine of Mata Vaishno Devi here.

Rajya Sabha member and AAP leader Raghav Chadha on Friday joined the BJP along with six other party MPs.

Reacting to the development, Gupta said, "With time, everyone gains wisdom. I believe that in the interest of the nation, everyone should come together so that all citizens can move forward and work collectively—that is the right path."

"I pray that the mother Goddess continues to bless all Indians and that the country keeps advancing under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. May every state and every citizen move forward," she said.

Extending a message to the people of Jammu and Kash-



"I pray that the mother Goddess continues to bless all Indians and that the country keeps advancing under the leadership of PM Narendra Modi"

mir, she said, "May the mother's blessings always be with them. I wish them happiness, good health and safety."

Earlier, the Delhi chief minister was warmly welcomed by BJP leaders and workers on reaching Katra town, the base camp for the pilgrims visiting the shrine.

MCD pedals for a cleaner, greener Delhi

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) organised an 8-km cyclothon in the Karol Bagh zone, aiming to promote physical fitness while reinforcing its Clean and Green Delhi Mission. The initiative brought together residents and municipal staff in a combined effort to raise awareness about sustainable living and civic responsibility.

The event commenced from Rajendra Nagar, where Deputy Commissioner Dilkush Meena flagged off the rally. Participants cycled along a designated route through key stretches of Karol Bagh, with the programme also incorporating a parallel cleanliness drive. Sanitation activities carried out along the route reflected the civic body's emphasis on integrating environmental awareness with community participation.

Officials noted that the cyclothon witnessed a strong turnout, with enthusiastic participation from both citizens and MCD employees. The event highlighted a growing



public inclination towards healthier lifestyles, alongside increased engagement in cleanliness and environmental campaigns. Many participants described the initiative as a meaningful way to combine fitness with social responsibility.

Speaking on the occasion, officials underlined the importance of such outreach programmes in building awareness at the grassroots level. They added that encouraging physical activity through community events could also contribute to improved public health outcomes, while simultaneously strengthening the message of main-

taining clean surroundings. The cyclothon forms part of a broader series of initiatives being undertaken by the MCD to foster a cleaner and greener urban environment. Civic authorities reiterated their commitment to organising similar events across different zones of the capital, with the objective of ensuring sustained public involvement in environmental and health-related campaigns.

The initiative underscores the evolving role of civic bodies in not only maintaining urban infrastructure but also actively promoting behavioural change among citizens.

TREE PLANTATION AT TILAK MARG UNDER 'EK PED MAA KE NAAM' CAMPAIGN

NDMC's green drive puts women at the fore

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) on Sunday organised a large-scale tree plantation drive at Tilak Marg under its ongoing 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' campaign, combining environmental awareness with a focus on women's participation and leadership.

Held as part of the 21st edition of the weekly initiative, the programme was themed 'Nari Shakti Vandan' and witnessed the participation of over 500 women from diverse profes-

sional backgrounds. The event began with a collective listening of the 133rd episode of Mann Ki Baat, reinforcing messages of environmental conservation and civic responsibility.

The plantation drive was attended by several prominent figures, including BJP national vice-president Baijayant Panda and New Delhi MP Bansuri Swaraj, alongside journalists and public personalities. Addressing the gathering, NDMC Vice Chairman Kuljeet Singh Chahal emphasised that the initiative was not merely an environmental effort but also a tribute to

motherhood and a step towards strengthening women's role in society.

Participants planted saplings in the name of their mothers, symbolising an emotional connect with the campaign's message. According to officials, nearly 200 Ashoka (Pundula) trees and over 500 shrubs were planted during the programme. The park at Tilak Marg will now be developed and known as 'Nari Shakti Vandan', envisioned as a dedicated space celebrating women's empowerment and contribution to society.

Chahal noted that the cam-

paign, inspired by the vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, is being conducted regularly to encourage mass participation. He added that citizens involved in plantation activities would be invited in the future to monitor the growth and upkeep of the saplings, ensuring long-term impact.

The initiative reflects NDMC's broader approach of integrating environmental sustainability with social messaging, as civic authorities seek to foster greater public engagement in building a cleaner and greener Capital.

'INDIA'S POSITION ON PALESTINE UNCHANGED'

No consensus on West Asia at BRICS meet due to differences: Sources

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Sharp differences among the BRICS member states over the US-Israel war on Iran stalled India's efforts to build a consensus position on the conflict during a meeting of the grouping in New Delhi last week, official sources said on Sunday.

There was no change in India's position on the Palestine issue at all, they said days after the meeting of the BRICS Deputy foreign ministers and special envoys on Middle East and North America held in New Delhi.

As consensus on the West Asia conflict eluded, a "chair's statement" was released at the end of the deliberations. India is the current chair of the BRICS.

The BRICS meeting of

Highlights

- » The BRICS meeting of officials on the Middle-East could not produce a consensus document because there was "sharp difference of positions among members who are party to the conflict", the sources said
- » It is learnt that the United Arab Emirates' position on the conflict resulted in the meeting ending without producing a collective statement
- » The Sharm el-Sheikh summit in October last paved the way for ending the Israeli military offensive in Gaza
- » The summit culminated in the conclusion of a ceasefire agreement in Gaza

officials on the Middle-East could not produce a consensus document because there was "sharp difference of positions among members who are party to the conflict", the sources said.

It is learnt that the United Arab Emirates' position on the conflict resulted in the

meeting ending without producing a collective statement.

Efforts to bridge the gaps by all others were not successful, the sources said.

On the Palestine issue, India had only as recently as in January reached an agreed position with the Arab League, including Palestine,

they said.

India has been clear in its support for a two-State solution, the sources said.

"Many BRICS members had hosted/supported/attended the Sharm el-Sheikh summit and the UNSC resolution 2803. These have been notable developments in the last year," a source said.

The Sharm el-Sheikh summit in October last paved the way for ending the Israeli military offensive in Gaza. The summit culminated in the conclusion of a ceasefire agreement in Gaza.

Following the BRICS meeting on Friday, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said the members expressed deep concern on the conflict in the Middle East and offered views and assessments on the matter.

In January, India and the Arab League nations had pitched for a sovereign and viable Palestine state living side-by-side with Israel.

A declaration unveiled at the end of the second India-Arab foreign ministers' meeting said the two sides reaffirmed their commitment to achieving a "just, comprehensive, and lasting peace in the Middle East in accordance to international law, relevant UN resolutions and the Arab Peace Initiative."

"They called for a sovereign, independent and viable State of Palestine based on 1967 borders, living side by side in peace with Israel. Both parties supported the practice of inalienable rights of the Palestinian people," it had said.

NGT issues notice to Govt over hanging glacier danger in central Himalaya

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The National Green Tribunal has sought a response from the Centre and others regarding the danger hanging glaciers pose in the mountain slopes of central Himalaya.

The green body was hearing a matter where it had taken suo motu cognisance of a newspaper report citing a study which flagged the environmental concern. In an order dated April 24, a bench of National Green Tribunal (NGT) Chairperson Justice Prakash Shrivastava and expert member Afroz Ahmad said, "The news item relates to danger posed by hanging glaciers on mountain slopes in central Himalaya, where unstable hanging glaciers on steep mountain slopes could trigger devastating avalanches and downstream disasters, a new study focused on a sensitive section of the central Himalaya has warned."

The bench referred to the report and said four researchers from the Indian Institute of Science, Indian Institute of Technology Bhubaneswar and the



Defence Research and Development Organisation, Chandigarh, had assessed such glaciers in the Alaknanda basin of Uttarakhand, a key headstream region of the Ganga.

It said, "Their findings revealed the scale of the growing but largely overlooked danger, and a sharp rise in human exposure, driven by rapid development in high-altitude areas. The newspaper states that such retreat has led to the detachment of tributary glaciers from trunk glaciers and has destabilised mountain glaciers (glaciers located on mountain sides) that were previously stable."

The bench also noted that using satellite imagery, elevation models and avalanche simulations, the researchers had assessed the farthest potential distance ice avalanches could travel and their likely impact,

and they concluded that in a worst-case scenario, modelled flows could reach major settlements, including Mana, Badrinath and Hanuman Chatti in Uttarakhand.

"The researchers argued that adopting targeted monitoring in high-risk Himalayan locations could significantly reduce future risks. While full-scale systems may be difficult to implement across such vast terrain, they said that identifying the most perilous glaciers and focusing resources would be a practical first step," it said, citing the report. The tribunal said the report indicated violation of the provisions of the Environment (Protection) Act, besides raising substantial issues relating to compliance with the environmental norms.

It has officially added the Union Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, Central Pollution Control Board, National Mission for Clean Ganga, Uttarakhand Tourism Development Board, and National Institute of Hydrology as the respondents in the proceedings.

Parrots are 'wild animals', rules Bombay High Court

Orders Maharashtra government to compensate farmer for crop damage

NAGPUR: The Bombay High Court has ordered the Maharashtra government to compensate a farmer for pomegranate trees damaged by parrots, ruling the birds are "wild animals" under the Wild Life (Protection) Act and the state must reimburse citizens for losses caused by its property.

The Nagpur bench of Justices Urmila Joshi-Phalke and Nivedita Mehta noted that if farmers are not compensated for losses caused by protected species, they might resort to measures that harm wildlife, thus defeating the very purpose of the Act, which explicitly covers parrots.

A copy of the order passed on April 24 was made available on Sunday.

The court passed the order on a petition filed by Mahadeo

Debate (70), a farmer from Hingli village in Wardha district, who claimed that his pomegranate trees were damaged by wild parrots from the nearby wildlife sanctuary in May 2016, and sought compensation for the same.

The court has ordered the government to pay Rs 200 per tree for damages caused to 200 trees.

The state government opposed the plea, claiming that government resolutions issued in the past stated that compensation can be granted only when wild elephants and bison damage fruit-bearing trees.

The court, however, refused to accept this contention, pointing out that the objective of issuing such resolutions was to compensate affected farmers for losses they suffered. **AGENCIES**

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NAGPUR: Amid backlash in Maharashtra, Bageshwar Dgham head Dhirendra Shastri on Sunday said he was "extremely sorry" for his remarks on Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj, which he claimed were twisted by some people on social media.

A row erupted after Shastri claimed at a programme in Nagpur that Shivaji Maharaj had expressed his desire to renounce his responsibilities as he was tired of warfare, and approached his "guru" Samarth Ramdas with his crown.

Addressing a press conference in Nagpur on Sunday, the spiritual preacher claimed that his remarks were misrepresented on social media.

Shastri said he was pained by allegations that he didn't respect Shivaji Maharaj, emphasising that his resolution on 'Hindu Rashtra' was inspired by the concept of Hindvi Swaraj.

"Forget about disrespecting him, I cannot even tolerate anyone criticising Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj in my dream," he said. Shastri clarified that he had tried to highlight Shivaji Maharaj's devotion towards saints, mahants, and goddess Tuljabhavan during his speech.

He had also claimed that Samarth Ramdas placed the crown offered to him by Chhatrapati Shivaji back on his head and instructed him to continue governing, reminding him that true service lies in fulfilling one's responsibilities despite personal exhaustion.

"Some people presented my narration in the wrong manner. If my remarks have hurt anyone's feelings, I am extremely sorry. I want to request that my statement should not be presented incorrectly, as I live and die for Shivaji Maharaj," he said.

Former Rajya Sabha member and Maratha royal, Sambhajiraje Chhatrapati, meanwhile

accused Shastri of presenting a "fabricated and misleading" account of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj, and urged the Maharashtra government to bar him from holding events in the state.

Sambhajiraje, a descendant of Shivaji Maharaj, said Shastri comes from the state (Maharashtra) where the great warrior Chhatrasal Bundela was inspired by Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj to fight the Mughals and establish an independent kingdom. He alleged Shastri doesn't know the history of his own state. "He comes to Maharashtra and narrates a fabricated and misleading history of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj, even claiming that Maharaj grew tired of fighting battles," he said on Sunday.

Calling the public response to the "fake godman's" discourses "extremely unfortunate," he said those who promote such people, including certain individuals and politicians, should

be set straight.

"The state government should ban such persons from holding events in Maharashtra," he said, adding that the spiritual and historical legacy of Hinduism is of the highest order, and it should not be disrespected by mixing it with inaccurate and misleading narratives.

Sambhajiraje further demanded that religious figures should speak about spirituality and avoid distorting history.

A day earlier, Maharashtra Congress president Harshwardhan Sapkal claimed Shastri's remarks reflected the BJP's deliberate attempt to distort history. He had demanded an apology from Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis, Union minister Nitin Gadkari and RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat, claiming that even though the "highly objectionable" remarks were made in their presence, none of them registered even a basic protest.

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Iran's FM returns

Earlier, Araghchi described his previous Pakistan visit as "very fruitful," noting appreciation for Islamabad's role in regional peace efforts while questioning US commitment to diplomacy. Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif said their discussions covered the regional situation and bilateral ties.

Amid heightened security, Pakistan had deployed over 10,000 personnel and restricted movement in Islamabad and Rawalpindi. Some measures were eased on Sunday. Separately, Sharif spoke with Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, reiterating Pakistan's willingness to act as a "sincere and honest" facilitator for peace.

Light rains

In Delhi, the mercury climbed to 42.1 degrees Celsius on Sunday, which is 3.1 degrees above the seasonal average. The Ridge area reported the highest temperature in the city at 43.5 degrees Celsius. A yellow alert has been issued for Monday, with forecasts indicating that temperatures could reach around 44 degrees Celsius.

Uttar Pradesh reported severe heatwave conditions across multiple districts. Banda emerged as the hottest location, recording a maximum temperature of 46.6 degrees Celsius. The extreme weather has also affected religious tourism in Ayodhya. Officials said daily footfall at the Ram temple has dropped sharply from over 100,000 visitors to fewer than 40,000 due to the oppressive heat. Neighbouring states Haryana and Punjab also experienced high temperatures. Narnaul recorded 44.2 degrees Celsius, while Bathinda reached 43.7 degrees Celsius, making them the hottest locations in their respective states. In Rajasthan, Barmer and Jaisalmer both registered temperatures of 46 degrees Celsius. Kota and Chittorgarh followed closely at 45.2 degrees Celsius. Most parts of the state reported daytime temperatures exceeding 40 degrees Celsius. Hill states were

not spared either. In Himachal Pradesh, Una witnessed severe heatwave conditions, while Dharamshala also experienced unusually high temperatures. A yellow warning has been issued for Kangra, Kullu and Mandi for Monday.

Uttarakhand recorded temperatures significantly above normal levels. Dehradun saw a maximum of 39.2 degrees Celsius, five degrees higher than the seasonal average, while Pantnagar recorded the state's highest at 39.8 degrees Celsius. In response, authorities ordered the closure of all schools and Anganwadi centres on April 27.

In the Jammu region, heatwave conditions persisted across the plains. Jammu recorded a high of 39.4 degrees Celsius, which is 3.7 degrees above normal. A meteorological official stated that hot and dry weather would continue in districts including Jammu, Kathua, Samba, Reasi and Udhampur over the next two days, with heatwave conditions likely at several locations.

Eastern India also experienced intense heat. Jharsuguda in Odisha recorded 44.8 degrees Celsius, the highest in the state. At least seven locations in western Odisha reported temperatures of 43 degrees Celsius or more, including Sonepur, Titlagarh, Bhawanipatna and Bolangir.

Southern states have also been affected. In Tamil Nadu, more than ten districts recorded temperatures exceeding 100 degrees Fahrenheit. Coastal regions and Puducherry are expected to continue experiencing hot and humid conditions through April 30.

Kerala remains under a yellow alert for high temperatures, with forecasts indicating that Palakkad could reach 40 degrees Celsius and Kollam around 39 degrees Celsius. Authorities have warned of discomfort due to humidity combined with elevated temperatures.

Despite the heat, large crowds gathered for the annual Thrissur Pooram festival in Kerala. The event was conducted in a subdued manner this year following a recent fireworks accident that claimed 15 lives. Officials issued advisories urging attendees to carry water, umbrellas and other essentials to cope with the extreme conditions.

Weather officials have indicated that some respite may arrive from April 28, when rainfall and thunderstorms triggered by a western disturbance are expected to bring down temperatures in parts of northern India. Until then, authorities continue to stress caution as the heatwave maintains its hold across the country.

AAP submits petition

The development follows a major setback for the party on Friday when seven of its members in the Upper House, including Raghav Chadha, Ashok Mittal, Sandeep Pathak, Harbajan Singh, Rajendra Gupta, Vikram Sahni and Swati Malival, resigned and joined the BJP. Explaining their decision, Chadha said the move complied with constitutional provisions. "According to the Constitution, two-thirds of the total MPs of a party can merge with another party," he noted, adding that AAP had 10 MPs in the Rajya Sabha.

Singh, however, disputed this interpretation, citing Supreme Court rulings in cases from Uttarakhand and Arunachal Pradesh. Referring to the Tenth Schedule, he said it "clearly does not permit such political defections".

Dismissing speculation that AAP MLAs in Punjab were in contact with the BJP, Singh described such claims as "false propaganda". He also claimed there was strong public opposition across Punjab to the MPs who left the party. Also, Singh said Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann has sought time to meet the President to raise the issue of the Right to Recall, stating that MLAs who had elected the MPs now felt "betrayed" and wanted them to resign if they were unable to fulfil their responsibilities. Separately, Singh rejected allegations related to the 'Sheesh Mahal' controversy involving AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal. The BJP, led by Delhi minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, had raised questions over a bungalow allotted to Kejriwal at Lodhi Estate, calling it "Sheesh Mahal 2" and alleging the use of private funds for premium amenities. Singh countered that the images circulated were fabricated and said the party would initiate defamation proceedings against those responsible.

Court can reject

surrender before the trial court and seek regular bail in terms of the decision in Satender Kumar Antil v. CBI.

The top court said such a direction was wholly without jurisdiction and said that if a court chooses to reject anticipatory bail, it may do so, but it cannot

compel the accused to surrender.

He framed a changing

the quiet rhythms of everyday life.

A protégé of French photographer Henri Cartier-Bresson, Rai developed a distinctive approach rooted in proximity and immersion. His images from landmark events such as the Bangladesh refugee crisis of 1972 and the Bhopal gas tragedy of 1984 remain etched in public memory. Among his most haunting works is a photograph from Bhopal showing an infant's lifeless face, an image that came to symbolise the human cost of industrial disaster.

Rai also produced intimate portraits of towering figures, including former prime minister Indira Gandhi, the Dalai Lama, Mother Teresa, filmmaker Satyajit Ray, and musicians Hariprasad Chaurasia and Bismillah Khan. His photographs often revealed dimensions of these personalities that went beyond public perception. One notable image shows a contemplative group of Congress ministers standing around Indira Gandhi as she sits at her desk, capturing both power and introspection in a single frame. Yet Rai's work extended far beyond headline events and prominent individuals. He consistently turned his attention to ordinary people and everyday scenes, elevating them through his eye for detail and composition. Much of his work, often in black and white, brought a sense of quiet dignity to the mundane, transforming fleeting moments into enduring visual records.

Reflecting on his craft in a 2023 interview, Rai described photography as a way to engage with life's constant changes. "It's been more than 55 years but the most powerful part about photography is life and nature are ever changing and ever challenging and that shakes you up," he said. He believed that capturing the essence of a moment created a form of history that could not be altered. "History is written and rewritten but visual history can't be re-written," he had noted.

Rai had a deep connection with Varanasi, where he documented the city's spiritual and daily life with remarkable depth. From cremation rituals to the Ganga aarti and bustling street scenes, his images portrayed a city alive with energy and tradition. Photographer Samar Jodha recalled that Rai captured

a Banaras that "hadn't yet learned to pose for the lens," reflecting its unfiltered character. Peers often spoke of Rai's intensity and commitment to his work. Photographer Aditya Arya said Rai's style placed him at the centre of events, unlike contemporary photojournalism that often relies on distance. "With his wide angle, he would be in the middle of the action," Arya said, highlighting how proximity shaped the emotional impact of Rai's images.

Over the years, Rai worked with leading publications such as Sunday and India Today, and his photo essays appeared in international outlets including Time, Life, The New York Times, The Independent and The New Yorker. He was associated with Magnum Photos, joining the prestigious collective in 1977 upon Cartier-Bresson's nomination. Rai also served on the jury of the World Press Photo three times and on UNESCO's International Photo Contest jury twice.

His contributions were recognised with numerous honours. He received the Padma Shri in 1972 for his coverage of the Bangladesh war and its aftermath. His photo essay "Human Management of Wildlife in India," published in National Geographic, earned him the Photographer of the Year award in the United States. In 2009, France conferred upon him the Officier des Arts et des Lettres.

Rai authored several books, including "Raghu Rai's India: Reflections in Colour and Reflections in Black and White" and "Exposure: Portrait of a Corporate Crime." At the time of his death, he was working on his 57th book. The Raghu Rai Foundation, established in 2010, has archived more than 50,000 of his images.

Condolences poured in from across political and cultural spheres. Prime Minister Narendra Modi described Rai as a "creative stalwart" whose work captured India's vibrancy with sensitivity, depth and diversity. "His passing is an irreparable loss to the world of photography and culture," Modi said.

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi said Rai preserved the nation's memory and chronicled its soul, while Priyanka Gandhi noted that his images recorded the joys and struggles of ordinary Indians. Senior leader Shashi Tharoor remembered Rai as an inspiration to an earlier generation of journalists, and Naveen Patnaik said his photographs were "living histories". Writer Varun Grover described him as a "silent storyteller" and "interpreter of light".

Continued from Page 1

Correspondents' Association dinner with guns and knives had written about targeting Trump administration officials.

The accused gunman's family had alerted police in Connecticut, Trump said, revealing new details about a chaotic encounter that disrupted one of Washington's glitziest annual events the night before.

Several world leaders, including Prime Minister Narendra Modi, expressed relief that President Trump and his top officials were unharmed, asserting that political violence has no place in a democracy.

"I extend my best wishes for their continued safety and well-being. Violence has no place in a democracy and must be unequivocally condemned," Modi said in a post on X.

Expressing shock at the incident, British Prime Minister Keir Starmer said that any attack on democratic institutions must be condemned.

French President Emmanuel Macron, Italian PM Giorgia Meloni, Canadian PM Mark Carney, Pakistani PM Shehbaz Sharif, Japanese PM Sanae Takaichi, Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu, Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum and Australian PM Anthony Albanese extended their full support to Trump, calling the attack "unacceptable".

Delcy Rodriguez, the acting President of Venezuela following the capture of Nicolas Maduro by US forces, also condemned the attack against Trump.

The suspect, identified as 31-year-old Cole Tomas Allen from California, has been arrested.

Quoting Acting Attorney General Todd Blanche, CNN reported that the suspect who charged through a security checkpoint at the event appeared to be "targeting Trump administration officials."

The suspect was not on their radar before the shooting, a law enforcement official was quoted as saying by the channel.

A CNN reporter who was outside the ballroom at the Washington Hilton said he saw a gunman opening fire just a few feet away. He was among the dozens of attendees who took cover as law enforcement swarmed the venue.

"Boom, boom, boom, boom is all that I heard, and many guests ducked under the table," a C-SPAN reporter at the dinner said.

Several protestors had lined up on the road outside the hotel, raising slogans against the Trump administration and Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth.

Asked how Saturday's incident impacts him as the US president, Trump told reporters he is in a dangerous job but that he is no "basket case."

"I like not to think about it. I lead a pretty normal life,

considering, you know, it's a dangerous life. I think I handle it as well as it can be handled," Trump said.

"I will say you had Republicans, Democrats, independents, conservatives, liberals, and progressives... everybody in that room, big crowd, record-setting crowd," he said.

"We had some great work done by law enforcement, but in light of this evening's events, I ask that all Americans recommit with their hearts in resolving our differences peacefully," Trump said at the White House, flanked by First Lady Melania, Vice President Vance, FBI Director Kash Patel and top officials, including Marco Rubio, Pete Hegseth, Markwayne Mullin, Todd Blanche, among others.

Law enforcement officials who have interviewed Allen's relatives, examined the gunman's electronic devices and his writings preliminarily believe he intended to target administration members in attendance at the dinner.

He attempted to charge into the cavernous ballroom at the Washington Hilton but was tackled to the ground in a violent scene that resulted in shots being fired, Trump being hurried off the stage and guests ducking for cover beneath their tables.

"It does appear that he did in fact set out to target folks who work in the administration, likely including the president," Blanche told NBC's "Meet the Press."

The suspect is believed to have purchased the two firearms he carried within the last couple of years, Blanche said. He is not being cooperative and is expected to face multiple charges on Monday.

Video posted by Trump showed the suspect running past security barricades as Secret Service agents ran toward him. One officer was shot in a bullet-resistant vest but was recovering, officials said. The gunman was taken into custody and was not injured, but was being evaluated at a hospital, police said.

"He failed," Blanche said on CBS's "Face the Nation." "Law enforcement did their jobs."

Authorities believe the suspect fired the shot that hit the Secret Service officer, who is expected to make a full recovery, Blanche said.

"He's going to be great, he's going to be fine, and thank God he was wearing a bulletproof vest," Blanche said Sunday on ABC's "This Week."

There were around 4000 people at the hotel premises at the time he said, adding that this was the first time President Trump was going to attend this annual dinner.

Trump has survived two assassination attempts over the past two years – first at a presidential election campaign rally in Butler, Pennsylvania, on July 13, 2024, and later in Palm Beach, Florida, on September 15, 2024.

'FIELDER SANDESHKHALI'S REKHA PATRA, RG KAR VICTIM'S MOTHER'

BJP committed to women security: PM

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday accused the TMC of “sheltering goons who torture women”, and said the BJP giving poll tickets to Sandeshkhali's Rekha Patra and the mother of the R G Kar victim is proof of the party's commitment to ensuring women's security.

Speaking at the Matua community citadel of Thakurnagar at Bongaon in North 24 Parganas district, Modi also said all refugees who took shelter in India following religious persecution in the neighbouring nation will be granted citizenship through procedures outlined under the Citizenship Amendment Act.

The BJP has fielded Patra from Hingalganj, and Ratna Debnath – the mother of the RG Kar hospital doctor who was raped and murdered, from Panhati – in the Assembly elections.

Sandeshkhali hogged the national limelight in 2024, after allegations of sexual abuse of women by local TMC leaders came to the fore. The RG Kar



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with West Bengal BJP president Samik Bhattacharya during a roadshow, in Kolkata, West Bengal, Sunday

hospital incident also took place that year.

The BJP's “commitment to the security of Bengal's women has been reflected” in its decision to give poll tickets to Rekha Patra and Ratna Debnath, Modi said.

“I pledge before the brothers and sisters of the Matua Namasudra community members that they will receive citizenship through the Citizenship Amendment Act. They will be provided the same documents

which other citizens of this country have,” he said.

“Don't fall for TMC's lies on CAA. All refugees will receive permanent address in this country,” he added.

The Matua community is a largely Hindu Namasudra Scheduled Caste group in Bengal, originating from East Pakistan (now Bangladesh), who migrated to the state facing religious persecution. They have significant presence in multiple districts across West Bengal

Highlights

- » 'I pledge before the brothers and sisters of the Matua Namasudra community members that they will receive citizenship through the Citizenship Amendment Act'
- » Don't fall for TMC's lies on CAA. All refugees will receive permanent address in this country, said Modi

and are believed to hold sway in around 70 Assembly seats.

The recent SIR exercise allegedly resulted in a significant number of voter deletions from the community, leading to perceptible angst among its members with regard to their citizenship status.

The PM, referring to the record turnout of over 93 per cent in the first phase of polls, said, “The TMC's arrogance was shattered in the first round, and the second phase will cement

BJP's victory in the state.”

The TMC has “stopped talking” about ‘Ma Mati Manush’, the party's slogan when it assumed power 15 years ago, because doing so “will expose the sins they committed in Bengal”, Modi alleged.

“While Ma (mother) is now in tears, Mati (land) has been handed over to syndicates and infiltrators and Manush (people) have been forced to leave the state in search of job opportunities elsewhere,” he said.

Modi also alleged that even the smallest of politicians as well as goons consider themselves the government under the Trinamool Congress regime in Bengal.

“The TMC's ‘nirmam sarkar’ (cruel government) stands with goons who torture women of this state. The time has now come to say we will tolerate no more,” he said.

“Miscreants who rape and torture women will be brought to justice after May 4 (day of the Assembly poll results) by the new BJP government of Bengal,” the PM asserted.

‘Magician has run out of tricks, young India can see through him’

Rahul met a group of young women from Delhi University

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday said the “magician” has run out of tricks and young India can now see through him, as he attacked the Prime Minister Narendra Modi-led government over the women's reservation issue.

Gandhi met a group of young women from Delhi University and said the more the women of India are empowered, the better it is for the country.

In a free-wheeling interaction, where he answered several queries from students, the Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha said that Gen Z women will lead the way for the country and it is everyone's duty to open every door for them.

“Really enjoyed meeting the young women from Gargi College and Delhi University. “Two things are clear: 1. The magician has run out of



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi interacts with students of Delhi University, in New Delhi

tricks. Young India can see right through him. 2. Gen Z is our future - and Gen Z women will lead the way. It is our duty to open every door for them,” the Congress leader said in a post on X.

“The future of our country is in safe hands,” he said.

Gandhi had targeted Prime Minister Modi during the debate in the Lok Sabha on the women's reservation bill, calling him a “magician”, but the Congress leader's remark was later expunged

from records.

The Congress leader also expressed his bias in favour of empowering women, saying they are more effective than men.

He lauded BSP chief Mayawati and former Tamil Nadu chief minister J Jayalalitha for their role in their respective states.

Gandhi also attacked the RSS during the conversation and dubbed it as the “bureaucracy of the Maharajah” who supported the British Raj.

On the women's reservation bill, the former Congress chief said the BJP wanted to bring delimitation through it, which could have led to a “war between the South and the North”.

“They suddenly brought this bill and we wanted them to give one-third of the 543 existing seats to women, but they did not do that. Actually, this is not the women's bill. It is very simple, it is delimitation,” he said.

BJP will end ‘goonda & ‘syndicate raj’ if it comes to power in Bengal: Shah

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: Union Home minister Amit Shah on Sunday said the BJP will end “goonda raj” and “syndicate raj” in West Bengal if the party comes to power in the state.

Addressing a public rally at Tehatta in Nadia district, Shah also claimed that voters “wiped out” the Mamata Banerjee government in the first phase of the Assembly polls itself.

“The BJP has already won 110 seats in the first phase of polls held on April 23,” he said.

“There will be an end to ‘goonda raj’ and ‘syndicate raj’ in West Bengal if the BJP assumes power in the state. Do



Union Home minister Amit Shah waves during a public meeting, in Tehatta, Nadia district, West Bengal

not be afraid to step out and cast your votes, as the Election Commission has made ample arrangements. Nobody will be able to stop you from voting,” Shah said.

He said if the BJP is voted to

power, it would identify “infiltrators hiding in the state” and take necessary action against them.

The senior BJP leader had to cut short his speech because of sudden heavy rainfall despite a large gathering at the venue.

Later, speaking at another gathering in Ranaghat in the same district, Shah alleged that most of the cattle smuggling takes place through Nadia.

“After forming the government in West Bengal, we will form a special squad to stop cattle smuggling,” Shah said, lambasting the Mamata Banerjee dispensation for allegedly helping the crime flourish.

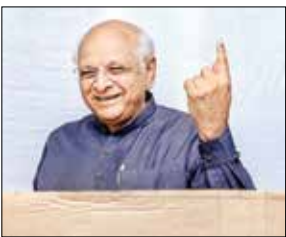
OUR CORRESPONDENT

AHMEDABAD: Voting for local body polls across Gujarat on Sunday was largely peaceful, with urban areas recording a turnout of under 50 per cent, while voters in tribal areas braved scorching heat to vote in large numbers.

According to the State Election Commission (SEC), municipal corporations saw a tepid 48.73 per cent turnout.

While Tapi, Navsari and Morbi civic corporations topped the turnout tally at 65.68 per cent, 59.68 per cent and 58.75 per cent, respectively, Vadodara, Surat and Ahmedabad recorded 47.26, 52.83, and 45.59 per cent, figures on SEC website showed.

Voting concluded at 6 pm,



Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel shows his inked finger after casting a vote in the local body elections, in Ahmedabad PTI

and the data shared by the SEC is provisional. It is likely to change with further updates.

The elections were held across 15 municipal corporations, 84 municipalities, 34 district Panchayats and 260 Taluka Panchayats, making it one of the largest electoral exercises in

the state ahead of the Assembly polls due later next year.

Municipalities recorded an average turnout of 59.09 per cent, with Bhabhar and Tharad in the newly formed Vav-Tharad district seeing the highest figure of 74.32 per cent. Gondal in Rajkot recorded the lowest turnout of 48.51 per cent.

Municipalities in Navsari and Chhota Udepur districts recorded turnouts of 72.56 and 72.04 per cent, respectively, the second and third highest amongst all districts, showed the data.

District and Taluka Panchayats recorded 60.9 and 62.04 per cent voter turnouts.

Local bodies in tribal-dominated districts of Narmada, Dangs and Tapi were among the top three in terms of turn-

outs in both the district and Taluka Panchayats elections.

Narmada dominated with a turnout of 80.66 per cent in district Panchayat and 80.92 per cent in Taluka Panchayat elections, while Rajkot, Bhavnagar, Amreli and Porbandar districts recorded the lowest turnouts.

Officials said the elections were largely peaceful.

Union Home minister Amit Shah and Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel cast their votes in Ahmedabad, while Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi voted in Surat.

Several areas across Gujarat recorded high temperatures, with the India Meteorological Department issuing a “yellow” alert and advising people to stay alert and take precautions while venturing outdoors.

Punjab Police security cover of MP Harbhajan Singh withdrawn

CHANDIGARH: The Punjab Police is learnt to have withdrawn the security cover of Rajya Sabha MP Harbhajan Singh, one of the seven lawmakers who switched to the BJP from AAP alongside Raghav Chadha, sources said.

The police security cover comprising 9-10 policemen was withdrawn on Saturday, they said.

The Punjab Police security was deployed at the former cricketer's residence at the Chhotti Baradari locality in Jalandhar.

AGENCIES

Congress releases manifesto for Haryana local body elections

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Former Chief Minister, Leader of the Opposition and Haryana Congress President Rao Narendra released the Congress party's manifesto for the local body elections. The party has pledged to create cities that are corruption-free, clean, and well-equipped with modern amenities.

Several senior leaders were present on this occasion, including Manifesto Committee Chairperson Geeta Bhukal, MLAs BB Batra and Aftab Ahmed, Panchkula mayoral candidate Sudha Bhardwaj, and Ambala mayoral candidate Kulwinder.

Speaking on the occasion, Hooda stated that this mani-



festo has been prepared with immense hard work. “It is an excellent and pragmatic document that takes into full consideration the interests of all sections of society,” he said.

“Under the BJP government's 11-year tenure, the condition of the cities has deteriorated severely. For instance, roads are in disrepair, sewage systems are clogged, and sanitation infrastructure is in

a dilapidated state. However, Congress is poised to win these elections, and this manifesto will be implemented with complete honesty and integrity,” he promised.

Haryana Congress president Rao Narendra Singh remarked that the Manifesto Committee prepared this document in a very short span of time by soliciting suggestions from the public. “It accords respect and attention to every section of society,” he said.

He asserted that under BJP rule, Nagar Nigams (municipal corporations) have effectively turned into Narak Nigam (corporations of hell). “Corruption has reached its zenith, it is for this very reason that the BJP has replaced 80 per cent of its candidates.

Kavitha comes with her own TRS; will it damage father BRS’ prospects?

Renaming the TRS as BRS was seen as losing the sentimental connection with people and the decades-old aspiration for Telangana statehood

OUR CORRESPONDENT

HYDERABAD: Former Telangana Chief Minister K Chandrasekhara Rao's daughter K Kavitha naming her party Telangana Rashtra Sena, with the acronym TRS resembling the original identity of BRS, has sparked a debate if it could damage the interests of her father's party.

The Bharat Rashtra Samiti (BRS), headed by her father, was originally named Telangana Rashtra Samiti (TRS), in lines with the sentiments of the Telangana statehood issue. However, it was renamed as BRS in 2022 following KCR's ambitious plan to expand the party across the country.

Renaming the TRS as BRS was seen as losing the sentimental connection with people and the decades-old aspiration for Telangana statehood.

The name change was believed to be one of the major reasons for BRS's defeat in the 2023 Assembly polls, ending a



Former Telangana Chief Minister K Chandrasekhara Rao's daughter, K Kavitha addresses the formation of her new political party 'Telangana Rashtra Sena' (TRS), at Munirabad

decade of the regional party's regime in the southern state.

Naming her outfit TRS, launched amid fanfare on Saturday, is seen as an attempt by Kavitha to claim the legacy of her father and the original TRS.

Her exit from BRS was acrimonious as Kavitha, former Nizamabad MP, was suspended for slamming her cousins and party leaders, T Harish Rao and J Santosh Kumar over an irriga-

Key Points

- » The name change was believed to be one of the major reasons for BRS's defeat in the 2023 Assembly polls
- » Naming her outfit TRS, launched amid fanfare on Saturday, is seen as an attempt by Kavitha to claim the legacy of her father and the original TRS

tion project.

Political analyst Telakapalli Ravi said Kavitha may become a rallying point for “dissidents and disgruntled elements of BRS” especially considering her main constituency would be BRS followers, given that her party's name is TRS.

“When Kavitha had indicated some time ago that her party would be named TRS, BRS immediately said they will

try to have their original name. That's a kind of boost for a political leader. She may even claim it to be her first victory,” he told news agency.

Ruling Congress would benefit to the extent she damages the prospects of BRS, Ravi added.

However, Kavitha is unlikely to emerge as a major force to challenge both the Congress and BRS, he opined.

He said Kavitha's party may impact BJP to some extent as the die hard supporters of Telangana identity may choose her party if they don't want to vote for Congress and BRS. Besides, Kavitha may also choose to attack the BJP on different issues, he said.

However, Telangana BJP chief spokesperson N V Subhash said Kavitha's party would not have any impact on saffron organisation.

“Why should people believe her. What way has she contributed to the development of Telangana. She has fallen into CM A Revanth Reddy's trap,” he told news agency.



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DIALOGUE RESUMPTION

Centre to hold talks with Ladakh groups on May 22, says L-G

MPOST BUREAU

LEH: The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has decided to convene a meeting of the sub-committee for political dialogue with representatives of agitating Ladakh groups on May 22, according to Lt Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena. The last meeting was held in early February.

Leh Apex Body and the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA), which have been jointly engaged in dialogue with the Centre since 2021 over their key demands, including statehood and inclusion under the Sixth Schedule for Ladakh, have been demanding the resumption of talks.

"I am pleased to announce that the Ministry of Home Affairs, Govt of India, has taken a decision to convene a meeting of the sub-committee for political dialogue on 22nd May.

"This will carry forward the process of constructive democratic dialogue with key stakeholders of Ladakh and pave the way for an enduring solution to meet the aspirations of the people of Ladakh," the Lt Governor said in a post on X on Sunday.

On April 14, the Lt Governor, who took charge in March, expressed confidence that the ongoing dialogue between LAB- KDA and the Centre will lead to a resolution, asserting that he remains available to support the process whenever required.

A day later, the KDA called for an immediate resumption of talks, asserting that they remain open to any fresh proposal from the centre, excluding council-based arrangements.

Punjab: Sehat Yojana aids premature baby's survival

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: The first cry of a newborn often signals relief, but for some families, it marks the beginning of an anxious battle for survival. At a private hospital in Bathinda, a premature baby's arrival turned into a test of endurance, medical skill and timely intervention.

Born at 33 weeks to Resham Singh and Gurmail Kaur, the baby weighed just 1.926 kg, significantly below the normal range. Struggling with severe respiratory distress, the newborn could not breathe independently and required immediate medical support. Doctors swiftly shifted the infant to the Neonatal Intensive Care Unit (NICU), where constant monitoring and assisted breathing became essential.

Under the care of Dr Surender Aggarwal, a senior paediatrician, the baby underwent 17 days of intensive treatment. The newborn remained on CPAP support for 10 days, followed by oxygen therapy for four days. During this period, neonatal jaundice developed but was effectively managed through phototherapy. Feeding and warmth were carefully maintained through limited Kangaroo Mother Care to ensure stability.

Doctors said progress in such cases is gradual and requires close observation. Over time, the baby's breathing stabilised, and overall responsiveness improved. Timely intervention played a crucial role in preventing complications. The treatment was provided under the Mukh Mantri Sehat Yojana, enabling the family to access cashless healthcare without financial strain. After over two weeks of care, the baby was discharged in stable condition, with weight increasing to 2.106 kg.

In a similar case, a newborn in Hoshiarpur also received treatment under the same scheme, highlighting the growing reach of healthcare support.



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

HIGHLIGHTS

» This will carry forward the process of constructive democratic dialogue with key stakeholders'

» On April 14, the Lt Governor, who took charge in March, expressed confidence that the ongoing dialogue between LAB- KDA and the Centre will lead to a resolution

"After the last meeting held on February 4, no further action has been taken so far. The Government of India, particularly the MHA, had promised that within 10–15 days, the next meeting would be convened, where Ladakhis' aspirations and demands would be considered seriously and sincerely. However, that day has not come yet," KDA co-chairman Asgar Ali Karbalai had said.

On April 18, former J-K Member of Legislative Assembly Deldan Namgyal and LAHDC Leh Councilor Smanla Dorje were released after spending nearly seven months in prison in connection

with the violence during protests in September that had left four persons dead and scores injured. Both LAB and KDA were consistently pressing for their release.

This came over a month after climate activist Sonam Wangchuk was released from Jodhpur Central Jail on March 14 following the Union government's decision to revoke his detention with immediate effect.

Wangchuk was taken into custody on September 26 under the National Security Act (NSA) pursuant to an order issued by the Leh district magistrate in connection with the violence.

The sub-committee was formed following a meeting held on February 19, 2024, between the High Powered Committee (HPC) and a 14-member delegation of LAB and KDA, representing various organisations of the Union Territory.

The Ministry of Home Affairs formed the HPC for Ladakh with a mandate to discuss the measures needed to be taken to protect the region's unique culture and language, taking into consideration its geographical location and strategic importance.

Punjab: From eco 'crusader' to MP, Seechewal stays loyal to AAP

SWATI MAHAJAN

CHANDIGARH: From rising to fame for cleaning and reviving the sacred Kali Bein river in the early 2000s to being elected unopposed to the Rajya Sabha in 2022 as an Aam Aadmi Party candidate, Balbir Singh Seechewal has chosen his principles over political opportunism.

As the lone Rajya Sabha MP from Punjab who did not change loyalties, his journey from an 'eco-baba' and spiritual leader to a parliamentarian stands out in an era of politics marked by frequent ideological shifts, reinforcing the idea of integrity in public life.

Six AAP Rajya Sabha MPs—Ashok Mittal, Raghav Chadha, Harbhajan Singh,

Balbir Singh Seechewal has chosen his principles over political opportunism

Vikram Sahney, Rajinder Gupta and Sandeep Pathak—recently switched loyalties to the Bharatiya Janata Party, with Seechewal being the only one to remain with AAP.

Seechewal built his reputation not through electoral calculations but through public service. He earned his image far from political corridors by reviving Punjab's historic Kali Bein river, associated with Guru Nanak Dev. Once reduced to a polluted drain, the river was

restored through his efforts. He mobilised thousands of volunteers—villagers, devotees and environmental workers—driven not by politics but by faith in the cause.

His perseverance paid off; hours spent standing in polluted waters helped revive the river and restore its flow. He gained widespread recognition, evolving from a spiritual figure into an influential environmentalist.

He continued his work in spiritualism, activism and public welfare long before his nomination to the Rajya Sabha.

Seechewal has termed the recent desertion of AAP representatives to the BJP as "opportunism". Speaking to mediapersons, he said those who left the party never considered him their colleague.

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on Sunday held coordinated protests across Punjab against Rajya Sabha MPs who recently defected to the BJP, with demonstrators raising slogans of "Punjab de Gaddar" and expressing anger over what they termed a betrayal of the state's mandate.

Protests were reported from multiple districts, including industrial centres, with party leaders, workers and supporters taking to the streets. In some places, tyres were burnt and slogans were raised against the defectors. A demonstration was also held outside the Trident Group, linked to one of the MPs, Rajinder Gupta.

AAP leaders described the defections as a serious breach of trust and demanded that the

CLOSER LOOK

- » Protests were reported from multiple districts, including industrial centres, with party leaders, workers and supporters taking to the streets
- » In some places, tyres were burnt and slogans were raised against the defectors
- » A demonstration was also held outside



the Trident Group, linked to one of the MPs, Rajinder Gupta

MPs' Rajya Sabha memberships be cancelled. They alleged that the leaders had switched sides under political pressure and opportunism, and said such actions would not be accepted by the people of Punjab.

Punjab Cabinet minister Harbhajan Singh ETO said Rajya Sabha members are expected to represent the state's interests in Parliament but accused the defectors of failing in that responsibility. He also alleged that central agen-

cies were used to pressure leaders into joining the BJP.

Another minister, Lal Chand Katarachakk, said the MPs had been elected with the support of AAP MLAs and should have worked to raise Punjab's concerns. He criticised what he described as attempts to destabilise opposition governments.

At a protest in Lehragaga, Minister Barinder Kumar Goyal said such political shifts would not affect the party's base, while

MLAs Balkar Singh Sidhu and Maninder Singh Giaspura said the defectors had misused the trust placed in them and would face public backlash.

AAP leaders reiterated that the party remains united and said the protests reflect public sentiment. They alleged that the defections were part of a broader political strategy aimed at weakening opposition parties, but asserted that the party's organisational strength in Punjab remains intact.

Manipur: NCB seizes 'heroin' worth Rs 11 cr

OUR CORRESPONDENT

IMPHAL: The Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB), in coordination with Manipur Police and the Assam Rifles, has seized a large consignment of suspected heroin and arrested three persons in Churachandpur district.

The operation, carried out on April 23 based on specific intelligence inputs, led to the interception of a Bolero camper at a checkpoint.

During inspection, officials recovered 474 soap cases concealing contraband believed to be heroin. The total seizure is estimated at around 5.42 kg, with a black market value of nearly Rs 11 crore.

Authorities said the arrests were made on the spot, with the accused allegedly involved in transporting the narcotics. The action is part of ongoing efforts to curb cross-border drug trafficking in the region.

Officials said further investigation is underway to trace the wider network linked to the consignment. The operation highlights increasing coordination among agencies to tackle illicit trafficking routes in the border state, officials added.

Parl panel 'taken aback' as NMC issues regulations without Law Min clearance

'Getting regulations duly vetted by Law ministry is a non-negotiable step'

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: A parliamentary committee has said it was "taken aback" to find that crucial regulations issued by the National Medical Commission were not vetted by the Union Law ministry, an essential prerequisite to prevent future infirmities.

In its report on "Infirmities in the regulations framed under the National Medical Commission Act", the Lok Sabha Committee on Subordinate Legislation said getting draft rules and regulations vetted by the law ministry from the legal, constitutional and drafting point of view is essential.

"The Committee, during an examination of the regulations published by the National Medical Commission (NMC) under the aegis of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, found to its surprise that one of

INSIGHT

» Keeping such instances in view, the committee recommended to the Health ministry 'to be alert' and ensure that such errors do not creep

up in future

» It also said that all the drafted subordinate legislations should be duly vetted by the law ministry before they are published in the Gazette of India

the most integral procedures in the framing of any subordinate legislation, that of getting it 'vetted' by the Ministry of Law and Justice from the constitutional, legal and drafting point of view was 'missed,' it said.

The report was tabled in the recently concluded Budget session of Parliament.

The committee report is based on the examination of the National Medical Commission (Recognition of Medical Qualifications) Regulations, 2023; Teachers Eligibility Quali-

fications in Medical Institutions Regulations, 2022; and the Medical Institutions (Qualifications of Faculty) Regulations, 2025, drafted by the NMC.

The parliamentary panel said it "was taken aback to find such occurrences" where the law ministry was not kept in the loop.

Getting bills, Acts, rules, regulations duly 'vetted' by the law ministry is a "non-negotiable step" which ought not be "missed" as had been "candidly accepted" by the representatives of the Ministry of Health and

Family Welfare also during the deposition before the committee, the report noted.

Rules, regulations and orders issued under a particular law are called subordinate legislation.

They are also called delegated legislation, as Parliament allows the executive to frame rules for the efficient functioning and implementation of laws passed by it.

"The nature of such delegated legislation, which is published in the Gazette of India, needs to be taken seriously. These delegated legislations, once in the public domain, form the fulcrum for subsequent executive actions by the nodal agency and, as such, merit utmost caution and due diligence to weed out any iota of mistake which could have serious legal ramifications on account of loopholes/vulnerability in the document," the panel cautioned.

Birthday boy opens fire in UP, three killed

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: A birthday celebration in Uttar Pradesh's Bulandshahr district turned into a gruesome triple murder after a dispute over smearing cake on the birthday boy's face spiralled into violence. Three young men from the same family were shot dead, leaving the area in shock.

The incident occurred late Saturday night at a gym on Subhash Road in Khurja, where a party was being held for Jeetu Saini. According to police, an argument broke out after some friends attempted to smear cake on Saini's face following the cake-cutting ceremony. The disagreement quickly escalated into a heated exchange.

Officials said the accused

left the venue but returned about an hour later with a few associates, carrying a licensed pistol. He allegedly opened fire on those present on the first floor of the gym. Amardeep (35), Manish (32) and Akash (19) were shot multiple times and died on the spot. Police said Akash was chased while trying to flee and was shot in the head.

The firing caused panic, with people taking cover inside the gym. Before fleeing, the accused allegedly removed the CCTV DVR in an attempt to destroy evidence.

Senior police officers reached the spot soon after. Over 15 people have been detained for questioning, and nearby CCTV footage is being examined. Efforts are underway to arrest the accused.

Punjab: AAP protests against 'defecting' MPs

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on Sunday held coordinated protests across Punjab against Rajya Sabha MPs who recently defected to the BJP, with demonstrators raising slogans of "Punjab de Gaddar" and expressing anger over what they termed a betrayal of the state's mandate.

Protests were reported from multiple districts, including industrial centres, with party leaders, workers and supporters taking to the streets. In some places, tyres were burnt and slogans were raised against the defectors. A demonstration was also held outside the Trident Group, linked to one of the MPs, Rajinder Gupta.

AAP leaders described the defections as a serious breach of trust and demanded that the

Hry to constitute social security body for organised workers: CM

MPOST BUREAU

Saini said that Haryana has become the first state to implement a 35% increase in minimum basic wages

ment security measures, the chief minister said the process of issuing appointment letters under the existing service security framework is underway. He assured that all eligible workers will receive appointment letters by June 15, a move aimed at strengthening job security and improving transparency.

Saini also stated that Haryana has become the first state to implement a 35 per cent increase in minimum basic wages under

the Code on Wages. Tracing the growth trajectory, he noted that minimum wages rose from Rs 2,903 in 2005 to Rs 6,289 in 2014, and have now reached Rs 19,425 under the current government.

Reaffirming the government's commitment to labour welfare, he said Rs 40 crore has been transferred directly into the bank accounts of 34,197 beneficiaries under 29 schemes through Direct Benefit Transfer. He added that technology-driven systems have improved transparency and efficiency in delivering benefits.

Referring to initiatives under Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Saini said over 54.32 lakh unorganised workers in Haryana have registered on the e-Shram portal, while 33.58 lakh workers are enrolled in the organised sector across 4.5 lakh establishments.

UP: Akhilesh Yadav questions 'handling' of Ghazipur incident

Ex-CM alleges pressure on victim family

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Samajwadi Party chief minister Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday raised questions over the handling of the Karanda Kataria case in Ghazipur, alleging that the truth cannot be altered by forcing changes in statements.

Yadav accused the state government of exerting pressure on the victim's family and said Uttar Pradesh has "never seen such a weak chief minister" who allows atrocities against poor and helpless victims while allegedly compelling them to change their statements.

He questioned the delay in registering the FIR and asked why the victim's version was allegedly altered. He also sought to know why the victim's family was being further harassed and who prevented action against those accused of pelting stones at the police. He raised doubts over the postmortem report and its credibility.

"The truth is known to everyone. Whatever the post-

mortem report may say, every household in the village knows the ground reality. People are aware of what happened and what is being made to be said," Yadav said, adding that the issue has triggered anger among sections of society.

Drawing parallels with the Hathras case, Yadav alleged that the Ghazipur incident reflects a pattern where victims belong to marginalised sections while the accused are from dominant groups. He questioned whether "cosmetic action" would ensure justice for the victim's family.

He further said that the root cause of such incidents lies in social discrimination and stressed the need to move beyond the idea of rule of law towards establishing "social justice".

Yadav described his party's PDA outreach as a broader movement aimed at achieving what he termed as "real freedom" after Independence, based on equality and social harmony.



EDITORIAL
DEFINING
PERMISSIBLE
PLAY

India's online gaming ecosystem is stepping into a decisive new phase. With the notification of rules under the Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming (PROG) Act, 2025, the government has effectively signalled that the long-debated question of “to regulate or not” is now settled. The answer is regulation—but with restraint. By attempting to draw a clear line between prohibited real-money gaming and permissible e-sports or social gaming, the framework seeks to impose order on a rapidly expanding digital sector without choking its growth. In doing so, it acknowledges both the economic potential of online gaming and the social risks that accompany it. The May 1, 2026, rollout marks not just the enforcement of a law, but the beginning of a structural shift in how India views digital entertainment—as an industry that requires oversight, accountability, and credibility.

At the heart of the framework lies a crucial classification exercise. The introduction of a time-bound “determination test” to identify whether a game qualifies as a money game or a legitimate e-sport/social offering is a significant step forward. For years, ambiguity in definitions allowed dubious platforms to operate in grey zones, often disguising gambling mechanics as skill-based gaming. The new rules attempt to dismantle that ambiguity by examining factors such as fee structures, expectations of monetary gain, and the monetisation of in-game assets. Importantly, the 90-day timeline for determination ensures that regulatory decisions are not indefinitely delayed—a chronic weakness in many Indian regulatory regimes. Yet this clarity also places a considerable burden on the newly constituted Online Gaming Authority of India, which must demonstrate both technical competence and institutional independence to avoid becoming either a bottleneck or a blunt instrument.

The creation of this “digital-first” regulator is, in many ways, the centrepiece of the new architecture. Positioned within the Ministry of Electronics and IT but drawing representation from multiple ministries, the authority is expected to function as referee, watchdog, and coordinator rolled into one. Its mandate—ranging from maintaining lists of prohibited games to issuing compliance directions and coordinating with financial institutions—reflects the complexity of the sector it seeks to regulate. However, such concentration of powers also raises familiar concerns. Will the authority be nimble enough to keep pace with a fast-evolving industry? Can it balance enforcement with innovation, particularly when dealing with emerging formats and cross-border platforms? And perhaps most importantly, will it operate transparently, with clearly articulated codes of practice, to inspire confidence among both industry players and users?

Equally noteworthy is the framework's emphasis on “user safety features,” an area that has often been treated as an afterthought in digital regulation. By introducing provisions such as age-gating, time restrictions, parental controls, and grievance redressal mechanisms, the rules attempt to address the psychological and financial risks associated with online gaming. The inclusion of counselling support and integrity monitoring tools signals a recognition that harm in digital ecosystems is not merely financial, but behavioural and social as well. Yet, the success of these provisions will depend heavily on implementation. Without robust auditing and enforcement, safety features risk becoming box-ticking exercises rather than meaningful safeguards. Moreover, the two-tier appeal structure, culminating in oversight by the IT Secretary, offers a pathway for dispute resolution—but also underscores the need for efficiency and responsiveness in handling user grievances.

The integration of banks and financial institutions into the compliance framework adds another layer of enforcement that could prove decisive. By empowering financial intermediaries to monitor transactions and act against unregistered or suspicious platforms, the rules extend regulatory oversight beyond the digital interface into the financial backbone of the gaming economy. This could significantly curb the proliferation of illegal money gaming operations. However, it also introduces practical challenges, particularly in distinguishing legitimate e-sports earnings from prohibited financial flows. Industry concerns on this front are not without merit. For a sector that aspires to global competitiveness, clarity in financial treatment and ease of doing business will be as critical as regulatory certainty. Ultimately, the success of the new playbook will depend on how well it balances these competing imperatives—curbing misuse without stifling innovation. If implemented with sensitivity and rigour, the framework could indeed be a game-changer. If not, it risks becoming yet another well-intentioned regulation struggling to keep pace with the realities it seeks to govern.

TALKING SHOP



RAJEEV NARAYAN

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In India, bonded labour survives not through the law's absence but through enforcement's failure. It maims the country's poorest and forces them to migrate, making them live in a corrupt silence that belies our tall ambitions

“The true measure of any society can be found in how it treats its most vulnerable members.”
— Mahatma Gandhi

This story begins with a promise. It also comes wrapped in urgency, in a desperation that smells faintly of hunger and cracked earth. A man from a drought-hit village in Odisha is handed Rs 10,000 in cash, more money than he has seen in a long time. The contractor speaks persuasively. There is work at a brick kiln 100 kilometres away. Food will be provided. Wages will follow. His family can come along. The decision is made instantly. It has to be. There are no crops to harvest, no savings, no time to negotiate. What looks like opportunity is grabbed. In truth, it is a transaction sealed in silence.

By the time the season ends, the promise has curdled into something dark. The Rs 10,000 has swollen into an unpayable debt, its arithmetic indecipherable. Wages shrink, vanish or are deferred. Work begins before sunrise and stretches past dusk. Movement is watched, often restricted. The children begin to work too, their small hands shaping wet clay into bricks, their childhood erased. The family does not leave. It cannot. This is not an aberration. It is a system. It is blatantly illegal, invisible and enduring. Nearly five decades after India abolished bonded labour under the Bonded Labour System (Abolition) Act of 1976, the practice continues to mutate and survive within the country's informal economy. It no longer relies on chains or confinement. Because now, bondage is engineered through debt, distance and despair.

A Deathly Trap

At its core, bonded labour is deceptively simple. A loan – often small and sometimes trivial – becomes the mechanism of control. Interest rates are opaque. Accounts are never settled. Wages are adjusted, deferred or denied. The borrower works not to earn, but to repay. And repayment never arrives – the ‘contract’ is designed that way. According to the International Labour Organization and the Walk Free Foundation, millions remain trapped in conditions of modern slavery, with South Asia accounting for a lion's share. In India, bonded labour persists across sectors that are ubiquitous and weakly regulated: brick kilns, stone quarries, agriculture, construction, domestic work and small manufacturing.



For instance, in Rajasthan's sandstone quarries, families labour under hereditary debt passed down through generations. In Tamil Nadu's textile belt, young women from marginalized communities are drawn into exploitative ‘Suman-gali’ schemes, where promised lump sums never materialize. In Uttar Pradesh's brick kilns, seasonal migrants are tied to advances that ensure their return, year after year. The system thrives, for it is calibrated to poverty. For those excluded from formal credit, a contractor's advance is not merely money; it is survival. And it comes at a cost that is existential.

Law's Dark Shadow
On paper, the legal map is clear. The Bonded Labour System (Abolition) Act of 1976 abolishes bonded labour and extinguishes the debts that sustain it. The Constitution, vide Article 23, prohibits forced labour. Courts have reinforced these protections. Yet the law stops where reality begins. Identification remains sporadic. Official numbers understate the scale. Conviction rates are dismal. Rehabilitation is delayed or inadequate, leaving workers vulnerable to slipping back into the same morass.

District-level vigilance committees exist only on paper. Administrative apathy, lack of training and local complicity weaken enforcement. For a system that operates in the shadows, the absence of sustained oversight is not a gap, but an enabler. As one field says: “Bonded labour does not persist because laws are absent, it thrives because accountability is non-existent.”

Multiplier Migrant

If debt is the mechanism, migration is the multiplier. Each year, lakhs of workers move across states for employment, leaving behind fragile lives in Bihar, Jharkhand, Odisha, Chhattisgarh and other Indian states. In this journey, they pass through contractors who mediate access to work. The workers are ideal targets. They are far from home, cut off from support systems, lack documentation and are unfamiliar with local laws. When exploitation begins, resistance is not just risky, it is impossible. COVID-19 exposed this reality. The image of migrant workers walking miles upon miles home was not a humanitarian crisis, it revealed the fragility of India's labour architecture, with bondage still thriving.

There is another dimension that implicates both India's contractors and its economic system. Bonded labour is embedded in supply chains that feed mainstream markets too, such as construction, exports and (even) global retail.

Corporate responses have been uneven. Layers of subcontracting obscure accountability. Audits are limited. The language of ethical sourcing sits uneasily alongside ground realities. This is not a moral failure; it is structural. When cost pressures cascade down supply chains, they land on the most vulnerable link: the worker. In that downward spiral, exploitation becomes not an aberration, but a business model.

Lives Stolen Forever

Beyond systems and statistics lies the human cost – quiet and devastating. Children born into bonded families inherit not just debt, but destiny. Education is stopped, often permanently. Health falls victim to relentless labour. Women face the double burden of working alongside men while confronting risks of abuse. In parts of this informal economy, that exploitation takes on a brutal form. In Maharashtra's sugarcane belt, women workers paid by output are penalized for missed days. Period pain, pregnancy or illness translate directly into lost wages or lost work. The body itself becomes a liability.

The consequences are chilling. Surveys in Beed district (a major sugarcane hub) report hysterectomy rates as high as 36 per cent, compared to a national average of 3 per cent. Investigations found that over 13,000 women, some under 25, had undergone removal of their wombs over a decade. There is rarely overt coercion. For many,

surgery is the only way to keep working and earning. Reforms, including medical check-ups, have struggled to stem the trend. Campaigners point to deeper causes: child marriage, early pregnancies and killing workloads imposed on adolescent girls. In this grim arithmetic of survival, the body is negotiated, altered and eventually sacrificed. Bondage extends far beyond labour – into autonomy, dignity and the most intimate realms of existence.

In a rescue operation in Karnataka, authorities freed workers from a kiln where they had been held for months. Among them were children who had never seen a classroom and adults who no longer believed escape was possible. Freedom, when it came, was not triumphant. For bondage does not end with release. It lingers in lost opportunities, broken confidence and the fear of going back.

Access to credit is critical to reverse this rot. Till the poor are excluded from institutional finance, the contractor's advance will retain its power. Financial inclusion is not just an economic goal, it is a tool of liberation. Corporate liability must deepen. Supply chains must be mapped and made transparent. Compliance must be a commitment, not a mere checkbox. Above all, there must be political will... recognition that bonded labour is not marginal, but central to questions of dignity, equity and justice.

Soliloquy: India stands at a crossroads. It speaks a story of growth, global leadership and demographic dividends. It builds highways, launches satellites and hopes to shape the future. Yet, in its kilns and quarries, fields and factories, a system that should have been killed decades ago thrives. Bonded labour exposes the distance between what India claims to be and what it still permits. The man from Odisha and millions like him are not seeking charity. They are asking for something more fundamental: the right to walk away. Until that right becomes real, India's progress will remain compromised. No nation can claim freedom while millions within it remain bound.

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FUNDING DEBATE



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The Bill aims to prevent misuse of funds. Critics argue stricter compliance norms may discourage genuine organisations and weaken grassroots initiatives

India's proposed FCRA amendment seeks stronger oversight of foreign funds, but its success depends on ensuring transparency without undermining legitimate civil society work

The proposed Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, reflects the Indian government's continuing effort to tighten oversight of foreign funding flows into civil society organisations. Positioned as a safeguard for national security, transparency, and accountability, the Bill builds on earlier amendments while introducing stricter compliance mechanisms. While critics caution against potential overreach and shrinking civic space, the legislation—viewed in a global context—aligns with a broader international trend among democracies of regulating foreign influence. A balanced assessment suggests that, despite legitimate concerns, the Bill addresses real vulnerabilities that merit policy intervention.

Why the Amendment Now?

India's foreign funding regulation framework has evolved steadily since the original Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act, 2010; which faced persistent enforcement challenges. Several documented instances provide evidence of systemic gaps, and thus the need for reform. The cancellation of licences of over 6,600 NGOs between 2017 and 2021—part of a broader trend involving over 20,000 cancellations since 2011—indicates widespread non-compliance in financial reporting and utilisation norms. Similarly, the Rajiv Gandhi Foundation and its associated Trust lost FCRA registration following government findings of violations in fund utilisation and compliance—though the issue remains politically contested. Investigations involving Greenpeace India highlighted government concerns—contested by the organisation—about foreign-funded advocacy influencing economic policy debates. The suspension of Amnesty International India operations in 2020 after its accounts were frozen amid allegations of routing foreign funds in vio-



India's new foreign funding framework must avoid becoming a tool of administrative excess

lation of FCRA provisions. Holistically, these cases reveal structural vulnerabilities that need to be addressed.

What the Bill Seeks to Do

In principle, the Bill aims to ensure that foreign contributions serve legitimate developmental or charitable purposes without undisclosed political or strategic implications. The Bill is expected to tighten compliance, enhance traceability of funds, and ensure that foreign contributions are not diverted toward activities deemed prejudicial to national interest. The government's rationale rests on two pillars: safeguarding sovereignty and improving financial transparency in a sector that has grown significantly in scale and influence.

From a governance perspective, such provisions signal a shift from reactive enforcement to preventive regulation.

The Civil Society Concern

Critics argue that tighter regulations risk constraining legitimate NGOs and shrinking democratic space. Con-

cerns include administrative overreach, potential targeting of dissenting organisations, and the chilling effect on advocacy work. There is also concern that excessive regulation could undermine India's vibrant NGO sector, which plays a crucial role in service delivery, rights advocacy, and policy feedback. The challenge, therefore, lies in distinguishing between necessary oversight and undue restriction.

Global Parallels and Precedents

India's approach mirrors global trends. The United States' Foreign Agents Registration Act (FARA) mandates disclosure of entities acting on behalf of foreign principals, focusing on transparency rather than prohibition. Australia's Foreign Influence Transparency Scheme similarly requires organisations to register activities undertaken for foreign entities.

Based on the above two, France legislated to create a public register specifically to track lobbying and influence

activities conducted on behalf of foreign entities. This became effective on 1 October last year. Similarly, Russia has enacted laws to monitor or restrict foreign-funded organisations, albeit with varying degrees of stringency and controversy.

These international precedents suggest that concerns about foreign influence are neither unique to India nor inherently incompatible with democratic systems.

The Real Challenge: Balance, Not Binary

The debate is often framed as a binary between state control and civil liberty. In reality, the challenge lies in maintaining balance between these two, and designing regulation that is effective yet fair. Excessive leniency risks misuse and opacity; excessive rigidity risks stifling legitimate work. Transparent, rule-based, and non-partisan implementation is essential for credibility.

Necessary Reform, If Judiciously Applied

On balance, the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, addresses a legitimate policy gap. In an era of complex geopolitical and informational flows, unchecked foreign funding can pose risks that extend beyond finance, into policy and governance. The evidence of systemic non-compliance and the evolving nature of foreign influence justify stronger regulatory oversight. At the same time, the concerns of civil society must result in safeguards against overreach. The true test of the legislation will not lie in its intent, but in its execution. Its judicious implementation can strengthen institutional integrity without undermining democratic vitality. In that sense, the need for such a law is not only understandable—it is, arguably, necessary. It is less an outlier and more a calibrated response to evolving risks.

Views expressed are personal

SUSPECT LEGALLY BOUGHT A PISTOL IN OCTOBER 2023

Media dinner shooting suspect wrote about targeting officials, says Trump

WASHINGTON: The man accused of opening fire at the White House Correspondents' Dinner sent writings to family members minutes before the shooting referring to himself as a "Friendly Federal Assassin," railing against Trump administration policies and signalling what investigators increasingly believe was a politically driven attack, according to a law enforcement official familiar with the investigation.

The writings, sent shortly before shots were fired at the Washington Hilton, made repeated references to President Donald Trump without naming him directly and alluded to grievances over a range of administration actions and recent events, including US strikes on drug smuggling boats in the eastern Pacific, the official said.

Investigators are treating the writings, along



Members of law enforcement respond during the White House Correspondents Dinner, in Washington

with a trail of social media posts and interviews with family members, as some of the clearest evidence yet of the suspect's mindset and possible motives.

Authorities also uncovered what the official described as numerous anti-Trump social media posts linked to the sus-

pect, Cole Tomas Allen, a 31-year-old California man accused of trying to breach a security checkpoint at the dinner while armed with multiple weapons.

Allen's brother contacted police in New London, Connecticut, after receiving the writings, according to the offi-

Highlights

- » The writings, sent shortly before shots were fired at the Washington Hilton
- » Suspect, Cole Tomas Allen accused of trying to breach a security checkpoint at the dinner
- » Allen's brother contacted police in New London, Connecticut, after receiving the writings'
- » Federal agents have also quizzed Allen's sister in Maryland

cial. A police spokesperson said they contacted federal law enforcement after receiving that information.

Federal agents have also interviewed Allen's sister in Maryland, who told investigators her brother had legally purchased several weapons from a California gun store

and stored them at their parents' home in Torrance without their knowledge, according to the official.

She described her brother as prone to making radical statements, the official said.

Allen legally bought a .38-caliber semiautomatic pistol in October 2023 and a 12-gauge shotgun two years later, the official and another law enforcement official told The Associated Press.

Authorities are still trying to determine how specific Allen's alleged targets were. Officials have said investigators are examining whether his grievances centered on Trump and Vice President JD Vance personally or reflected a broader hostility toward the administration.

The officials were not authorised to discuss the ongoing investigation and spoke to AP on condition of anonymity.

Two former Israeli PMs agree to merge parties against Netanyahu

JERUSALEM: Two Israeli political heavyweights on Sunday said they would join forces in upcoming elections in a shared effort to unseat long-time Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu.

Naftali Bennett and Yair Lapid served as prime ministers in a rotation agreement as part of a coalition government they formed in 2021. They now plan to merge their parties into single faction headed by Bennett.

"The move is intended to unite the bloc, put an end to internal divisions and focus all efforts on winning the critical upcoming elections," Lapid's Yesh Atid party said in a statement.

Bennett and Lapid scheduled a joint news conference later on Sunday.

The 2021 coalition agreement ended 12 years of Netanyahu rule. Bennett served as prime minister for the first year until their coalition fractured. Lapid then held the top job as caretaker prime minister for the final six months until new elections



Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu

'The move is intended to unite the bloc, put an end to internal divisions and focus all efforts on winning critical upcoming elections'

brought Netanyahu back to power.

Lapid has served as Israel's opposition leader since that time, while Bennett took a

break from politics.

The two men have ideological differences.

Bennett is an Orthodox Jew with hard-line views toward the Palestinians, while Lapid is secular and seen as more moderate. But they enjoyed a close working relationship during their short-lived coalition.

Their alliance is aimed at uniting a fragmented opposition that appears to have little in common beyond their shared hostility toward Netanyahu.

Philippine officials say 2 Americans among 19 killed in Negros clash

MANILA: Two Americans were among 19 suspected communist guerrillas who were killed in clashes with Philippine troops in a central province earlier this week, a government anti-insurgency task force said Saturday night.

The National Task Force to End Local Communist Armed Conflict said the Americans were killed with 17 other suspected New People's Army guerrillas in a series of clashes with army forces on April 19 in the coastal town of Toboso in Negros Occidental province. The deadly fighting was first reported on Monday.

The task force warned Americans of Filipino descent in the United States to be wary of being lured by left-wing activist groups into joining or supporting Filipino insurgents in the Philippines in a recruitment process it described as "terror-grooming".

The US and the Philippines have separately designated the New People's Army as a terrorist organisation.

Human rights groups, however, called for an independent investigation into the clashes, saying that civilians were killed including a student leader from the state-run University of the Philippines, two local advocates for farmers' rights and a local community journalist who

The US and the Philippines have separately designated the New People's Army as a terrorist organisation

wanted to show support for impoverished villagers.

"We call on the international community to monitor this case closely, as it is not an isolated incident but part of a continuing pattern of International Humanitarian Law violations across the Philippine countryside," the National Union of People's Lawyers, a human rights group, said.

Undersecretary Ernesto Torres Jr., the executive director of the counterinsurgency task force, identified the two slain Americans as Lyle Prijoles and Kai Dana-Rene Sorem.

The US Embassy in Manila did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

Torres said that all 19 people killed have been identified and their remains have been turned over to family. "These facts point to a disturbing convergence: foreign nationals in a live combat setting, where the risks are immediate and the consequences irreversible," he said.

UK PM calls Trump after shooting in DC

LONDON: British Prime Minister Keir Starmer on Sunday called US President Donald Trump to express his "relief" that he was safe following the shooting incident at the White House Correspondents Dinner in Washington DC.

Trump had been hurriedly evacuated from the venue after an armed man rushed past a security checkpoint on Saturday night.

A US Secret Service officer was shot at from close-range in the clash but saved by his bullet-proof vest.

"He [Starmer] extended his best wishes to the president and first lady following the shocking scenes at last night's White House Correspondents Dinner.

He expressed his relief that the president and first lady were safe and wished a speedy recovery to the officer injured," a Downing Street spokesperson said after the phone call.

AT LEAST 16 DEAD IN STRIKES ACROSS UKRAINE - Chernobyl anniversary highlights nuclear risks of Russia-Ukraine war

KYIV: At least 16 people have been killed in strikes over the weekend across Ukraine, Russian-occupied territory and Russia, local authorities said, as the 40th anniversary of the Chernobyl nuclear disaster prompted fresh warnings about the risks posed by attacks near the plant during Russia's more than four-year invasion of its neighbour.

The death toll from Russian drone and missile strikes on the city of Dnipro rose to nine, regional head Oleksandr Hanzha said Sunday.

One man was killed in a Ukrainian drone strike on the port city of Sevastopol, in Russian-occupied Crimea, Moscow-installed authorities said Sunday. Leonid Pasechnik, the Russia-installed governor in Ukraine's Luhansk region — of which Russia earlier this month said it had taken full control, a claim denied by Ukraine — said three people were killed in an overnight Ukrainian drone



Ukraine marks the 40th anniversary of the Chernobyl nuclear accident

THE LATEST STRIKES CAME AFTER A WOMAN WAS KILLED IN A UKRAINIAN ATTACK ON BELGOROD BORDER REGION

strike on a village, after report-

ing two people were killed in the early hours of Saturday.

Ukraine did not comment on either attack, which could not be independently verified by The Associated Press.

The latest strikes came after a woman was killed in a Ukrainian drone attack on Russia's Belgorod border region, according to local authorities.

Explosion in Colombia kills at least 13, injures 38

BOGOTA: An explosive device killed 13 people travelling on a bus in southwestern Colombia on Saturday, an attack the country's army chief described as a "terrorist act" that also left at least 38 injured as violence linked to drug trafficking in the region escalates.

Octavio Guzman, the governor of the region of Cauca, said on X that the device was set off while the bus was travelling along the Panamerican Highway in the municipality



A man looks at vehicles damaged in an attack on the Pan-American Highway that killed at least a dozen people in Combia on Sunday

of Cajibío. Five children were among

the injured, Cauca Health Secretary Carolina Camargo told

Noticias Caracol, a TV news program.

Gen. Hugo Lopez, commander of Colombia's Armed Forces, told a news conference that it was a "terrorist act" and blamed the network of a man known as "Ivan Mordisco" — one of Colombia's most wanted figures — and the Jaime Martínez faction. Both are dissidents of the now-defunct Revolutionary Armed Forces of Colombia that operate in the region.

China launches Pakistani satellite

BEIJING: China launched a Pakistani satellite from its Taiyuan Satellite Launch Centre in north China's Shanxi Province on Saturday night.

The satellite named PRSC-EO3 was lifted off at 8:15 p.m. (Beijing Time) by a Long March-6 carrier rocket and successfully entered its planned orbit, China's state-run Xinhua news agency reported.

This is the fourth Pakistani satellite launched by China since last year. China launched three Pakistani satellites last year. China has been launching satellites for Pakistan in the last few years, broadening its all-weather alliance with Pakistan into the space arena.

Separately, two Pakistanis who were selected by Beijing for astronaut training to participate in China's space mission training arrived here on April 24.

The astronauts reached the Astronaut Centre of China in Beijing on Friday to join training alongside their Chinese peers, the China Manned Space Agency announced. Upon completing all required training and passing the assessments, one of the two will participate in a space mission as a payload specialist.

Threat of light pollution puts world's darkest skies in Atacama Desert at risk

Every year, Atacama Desert draws thousands of astronomers & scientists from around the world

THE ATACAMA DESERT: It takes a moment for the eyes to adjust. A faint spark appears in the darkness; then another, brighter one. Soon, stars, planets and entire constellations emerge. Before long, a whole galaxy stretches across the sky, visible to the naked eye.

In Chile's Atacama Desert, the night sky feels infinite. Considered the driest place on Earth, its darkness is also one of the clearest windows to the universe.

A rare combination of dry climate, high altitude and, crucially, isolation from urban light pollution, makes the Atacama an unrivaled hub for world-class astronomy and home to the world's largest ground-based astronomical projects.

"The conditions in the Atacama Desert are unique in the world," said Chiara Mazzucchelli, president of the Chilean Astronomical Society. "There are more than 300 clear nights per year, meaning no clouds



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

and no rain."

But the world's darkest skies may be at risk.

Last year, the desert became a battleground between scientists and an energy firm proposing a green power complex just kilometers (miles) from the Paranal Observatory. Managed by the European Southern Observatory, ESO, the site also is the future home to what is to be the most powerful optical telescope ever built.

Although the energy project was canceled in January following a massive appeal from astronomers, physicists and Nobel laureates, it exposed deep concerns that existing sky preservation laws are lax, outdated and unclear.

Since then, several environmental regulations have come under review, including one from Chile's science ministry targeting protected astronomical zones.

Highlights

- » Last year, the desert became a battleground between scientists and an energy firm proposing a green power complex
- » Although the energy project was canceled in January following a massive appeal from astronomers, physicists and Nobel laureates

"We are working to ensure the new criteria are strict enough to guarantee that there will be no impact on astronomical areas," said Daniela González, director of the Cielos de Chile Foundation, a nonprofit founded in 2019 to protect the quality of Chile's night skies.

The Associated Press spent three days visiting the Paranal facilities in the heart of the so-called Photon Valley. In this

high-altitude corridor, several observatories operate side by side using some of the most sophisticated instruments ever engineered. "Many of these large facilities are located in Chile, and ESO's telescopes in particular are the most powerful astronomical facilities on the planet," said Itziar de Gregorio-Monsalvo, the inter-governmental organization's representative in Chile.

Paranal is one of nearly 30 astronomical sites in northern Chile, most of which are managed by international organizations. Every year, the Atacama Desert draws thousands of astronomers and scientists from around the world to investigate the origins of the universe. "We are lucky to be here," said Julia Bodensteiner, an assistant professor at University of Amsterdam, noting that the chances of being selected as a visiting astronomer at Paranal are just 20 to 30 per cent.

World Briefs

MALI SEPARATISTS CONFIRM THEY JOINED ISLAMIC MILITANTS

DAKAR: Separatists in northern Mali said they joined Islamic militants in launching one of the biggest coordinated attacks on the Malian army in the capital and several other cities that left at least 16 wounded. It was the first time that a Tuareg-led separatist group, the Azawad Liberation Front (FLA), said it had operated alongside the al-Qaida-linked militant group JNIM, which also claimed responsibility for Saturday's attacks on Bamako's international airport and four other cities in central and northern Mali. "This operation is being carried out in partnership with the JNIM, which is also committed to defending the people against the military regime in Bamako," FLA spokesperson Mohamed El Maouloud Ramadan said in a statement Saturday.

SYRIA'S FIRST PUBLIC TRIAL OF ASSAD-ERA OFFICIALS OPENS IN DAMASCUS

DAMASCUS: The first public trial in Syria of officials linked to the rule of former President Bashar Assad opened in Damascus Sunday. Atef Najib, a former Syrian army brigadier general who was head of the Political Security Branch in southern Syria's Daraa province under Assad, appeared in the courtroom to face charges related to "crimes against the Syrian people," state-run news agency SANA reported. Najib was in that position in 2011 when teenagers who scrawled anti-government graffiti on a school wall in Daraa were arrested and tortured.

RIL navigates volatile oil mkts with agile sourcing, operational tweaks

After disruption oil & gas flows from Gulf nations, Reliance tapped non-Persian Gulf suppliers to replace barrels lost due to Iran war

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India's largest private refiner Reliance Industries Ltd relied on diversified crude sourcing and operational agility to navigate a volatile energy market during the last quarter of FY26, marked by geopolitical disruptions and sharp cost swings.

After the Iran war disrupted oil and gas flows from Gulf countries, Reliance, which operates the world's largest oil refining complex at Jamnagar in Gujarat — tapped non-Persian Gulf suppliers to replace barrels lost due to the conflict, according to an investor presentation the company made post fourth quarter earnings announcement.

"Persian Gulf loading contracts were replaced to minimize run cut," it said. "Crude sourcing diversified from multiple geographies." Reliance said it "worked with Middle East suppliers on alternative routing for stranded crude." It, however, did not elaborate.

Global crude markets remained largely oversupplied through most of the 2025-26 fiscal year, even as sanctions by the US and EU on Russian oil tightened before easing in



'Persian Gulf loading contracts were replaced to minimize run cut,' it said. 'Crude sourcing diversified from multiple geographies,' the company added

March 2026. At the same time, structurally tight refining capacity and stronger-than-expected demand growth of about 0.8 million barrels per day in calendar 2025 drove a sharp rebound in fuel cracks.

However, downstream chemicals came under pressure due to oversupply, while prolonged conflict in the Middle East towards the end of the year triggered supply chain disruptions and dislocation in energy

markets.

Against this backdrop, Reliance moved quickly to secure feedstock and sustain operations. The company replaced Persian Gulf loading contracts to avoid refinery-run cuts and worked with suppliers in the region to reroute stranded crude. It also diversified sourcing across geographies and ensured feedstock security for both refinery-linked and ethane-based operations.

Highlights

- » Reliance said it 'worked with Middle East suppliers on alternative routing for stranded crude.' It, however, did not elaborate
- » It diversified sourcing across geographies & ensured feedstock security for both refinery-linked, ethane-based operations
- » Reliance expects energy markets to remain volatile amid geopolitical risks and trade tensions

freight and insurance costs.

This, along with the reintroduction of the Special Additional Excise Duty (SAED), weighed on margins for domestic fuel sales. Reliance responded by diverting propane and butane streams to boost LPG output and allocating KG-D6 gas to priority sectors. It also recalibrated its fuel mix, increased gasifier output and optimised grid power sourcing to reduce costs.

Looking ahead, Reliance expects energy markets to remain volatile amid geopolitical risks and trade tensions. Global oil demand is projected to decline marginally in 2026, while refining capacity additions are likely to remain constrained.

Fuel cracks are expected to stay elevated in the near term before easing gradually as supply normalises. Policy risks, including potential price controls and duties such as SAED, could continue to weigh on margins.

The company said its high-complexity refining system, diversified sourcing strategy and focus on maximising value across the chain would remain key to sustaining performance in a challenging environment.

Russia oil import data confidential, CCI backs Oil Ministry's denial

An RTI plea sought details of Russian oil imports from June 2022 to June 2025, including firm-wise breakup

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Data on oil imports from Russia to India cannot be provided as it is exempted under the RTI Act due to its "commercial and confidential" nature, according to the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC) under the Oil Ministry, with the Central Information Commission too backing it, citing strategic and economic interests of the country.

The case relates to an RTI plea seeking details of crude oil imported from Russia to India between June 2022 and June 2025, including a company-wise breakup for firms such as IOCL, BPCL, HPCL, ONGC Videsh, Reliance Industries and Nayara Energy.

The Central Public Information Officer (CPIO) had denied the information, stating: "The information pertaining to country-wise and company-wise details of crude oil import is of commercial and confidential nature and is exempted from disclosure under section 8(1) (d&e) of the RTI Act 2005. However, the total quantity and value of crude oil import (both current and historical) can be downloaded from the PPAC website."

The First Appellate Authority upheld this reply.

During the hearing recently,



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the appellant argued that the information was not provided and said he wanted to understand how India is functioning in the sector.

In its interim decision, the Commission observed that disclosure of the requested data "would prejudicially affect the strategic and economic interest of the State and also affect the relations with foreign states," adding that the information is linked to geopolitical relations.

It held the exemption valid under Sections 8(1)(a) and 8(1)(d) of the RTI Act, and said no further relief was warranted.

The Commission also issued a show-cause notice to the official concerned of the PPAC, which functions under the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, for being absent from the hearing despite receiving prior notice, asking why a penalty under Section 20(1) of the RTI Act should not be imposed.

The Commission added that "the respondent's website with respect to the Right to Information tab does not have any information," and directed the authority "to ensure compliance with Section 4 of the RTI Act, 2005."

Invoking its powers under Section 25(5) of the RTI Act, the Commission also recommended that the public authority improve suo motu disclosures under Section 4(1)(b).

These include publishing details of its organisation, functions and duties; powers and duties of officers and employees; categories of documents held; a directory of officers and employees; and the monthly remuneration received by each officer and employee, including the system of compensation as per regulations.

CIL plans 10-year roadmap to cut 243 MT coal imports

NEW DELHI: Coal India Ltd (CIL) is preparing a 10-year roadmap to cut India's 243 million tonnes (MT) of coal imports by boosting domestic output, improving coal quality and achieving logistics cost parity.

The plan, covering 2026-2036, will target substitution of all "substitutable" imports through higher production, beneficiation and efficient transport systems. It will include a forensic audit of imports, sector-specific policies and phased strategies to strengthen local supply, a source said.

CIL also plans to develop a National Washery & Logistics Grid to streamline coal washing and transportation, addressing key supply chain bottlenecks.

The company may appoint a consultant to help design the roadmap and suggest measures, including non-tariff interventions.

The move comes as India seeks to reduce coal imports to enhance energy security, lower foreign exchange outgo and support cleaner energy goals under the coal gasification mission.

CIL, which accounts for over 80 per cent of domestic coal output, produced 768.1 MT in FY26 and aims to scale up production to 1 billion tonnes by 2028-29.

It said key projects, clearances, land acquisition and evacuation infrastructure have been identified to meet this target.

HPCL says leak likely caused refinery fire, CDU restart seen by mid-May

NEW DELHI: Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Limited (HPCL) has said a hydrocarbon leak was the likely cause of the April 20 fire at its joint venture refinery in Rajasthan, adding that restoration work should be completed within three to four weeks. The crude distillation unit (CDU), the refinery's main unit, is expected to restart in the second half of May.

The fire broke out at the Rs 79,450-crore refinery of HPCL Rajasthan Refinery Ltd a day before its scheduled inauguration.

In a stock exchange filing, HPCL said the blaze was confined to the heat exchanger stack, affecting six exchangers and related equipment.

Based on preliminary findings, the fire is suspected to have originated from a leak at a pressure gauge tapping



The refinery's inauguration has been postponed, with a revised date yet to be announced

point on the vacuum residue exchanger inlet line.

HPCL said other secondary units are at advanced stages of commissioning and progressing as planned. Trial production of LPG, petrol, diesel and naphtha is expected to begin in May, followed by stabilisation and full commissioning.

The refinery's inauguration has been postponed, with a revised date yet to be announced. The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas has ordered a separate probe by former MRPL chief M Venkatesh.

The refinery, located in Rajasthan's Balotra district, is designed as a 9 million tonnes per annum facility with a strong petrochemical focus.

It has a Nelson Complexity Index of 17 and petrochemical yields exceeding 26 per cent, enabling processing of heavier crude into high-value products.

This will be India's 24th refinery and among its most complex. The project is a joint venture between HPCL (74 per cent) and the Rajasthan government (26 per cent), and is expected to produce fuels and petrochemicals widely used across industries.

Adani Green Energy to invest ₹15K cr to add 10 gigawatt-hours battery storage in FY27

NEW DELHI: Adani Green Energy Ltd plans to invest about Rs 15,000 crore to add more than 10 gigawatt-hours (GWh) of battery energy storage capacity in the current financial year, as it pivots towards delivering reliable, dispatchable clean power amid India's accelerating energy transition.

The proposed addition will be over and above the roughly 3 GWh of installed storage capacity the company expects to reach shortly, following the commissioning of 1.4 GWh during FY26, it said during its earnings call. The batteries are being developed alongside renewable generation at Khavda in Gujarat, where AGEL is building what it describes as the world's largest renewable energy park.

The storage systems are aimed at supplying power during peak evening demand when



solar output tapers, helping smooth load profiles and enable round-the-clock renewable energy. "We are in the process of very significantly ramping up our capacity addition for batteries which we expect to commission north of 10 GWh, in this fiscal," Executive Director Sagar Adani said.

"In FY26 we added 1.4 GWh and we hope that in the next few days we should reach the mark of 3 GWh of installed capacity in Khavda," he added.

AGEL already has 19.3 GW of operational renewable energy

The current capacity comprises 70% solar project, 13 per cent wind and 17% hybrid

portfolio — India's largest — and is targeting 50 GW by FY30, according to the investor presentation post-Q4 earnings.

The current capacity comprises 70 per cent solar project, 13 per cent wind and 17 per cent hybrid.

During FY26, it generated 38 billion units of electricity, 34 per cent more than 28 billion in the previous financial year.

On battery storage, the planned 10+ GWh of capacity will include 75 per cent that is backed by 25-year fixed tariff power purchase agreements

(PPAs), according to the presentation. AGEL's expansion into battery storage reflects a broader shift in India's power sector, where the focus is moving from rapid renewable capacity addition to ensuring grid stability and reliable supply.

India's grid-scale battery storage ecosystem is still at a nascent stage, with projects under various phases of commissioning and integration despite growing policy support and tender activity.

As renewable penetration rises and electricity demand increases, storage is expected to play a key role in balancing supply and managing peak loads.

By scaling up storage alongside generation, AGEL is positioning itself to deliver firm and flexible clean energy, aligning with the next phase of India's energy transition.

WGC proposes physically-backed common infrastructure to advance digital gold growth

MUMBAI: The World Gold Council (WGC) has proposed an initiative to build a physically-backed shared infrastructure to advance the growth of digital gold.

WGC through a white paper has proposed the concept of 'Gold as a Service', a platform owned and operated by the World Gold Council and built as shared infrastructure that any market participant can access to build digital gold products without needing to develop their own end-to-end systems.

While digital gold products exist, they operate across fragmented infrastructure with inconsistent custody standards, redemption terms and gover-

nance frameworks, WGC Chief Strategy Officer Terry Heymann said.

"The idea behind this initiative is to provide a shared infrastructure which could help gold to play a greater role in the digital economy. This will be backed by physical gold this will be accredited, inspected regularly, with processes in place to make sure that gold has been responsibly sourced and is accounted for," Heymann said.

Gold as a service aims to strengthen trust, reduce complexity, and enable digital gold to function as a coherent, interoperable asset class fit for a digital financial era, he noted.

Such infrastructure aims

change how gold participates in the financial system, he said.

According to the WGC white paper, the investor behaviour is shifting toward digital access. Retail investors increasingly use digital platforms and expect fractional ownership, seamless transferability and real-time settlement.

Recent ETF (Exchange Traded Funds) inflows and the growth of tokenised gold signal rising demand for digital exposure, however, digital gold remains small relative to the broader market due to structural frictions that limit scale and integration.

These structural frictions constrain fungibility, frag-

ment liquidity, and limit gold's broader financial utility and without common infrastructure, digital gold risks remain a collection of isolated products rather than a unified asset ecosystem.

"So we are just getting started on that. There's been an ongoing conversation around the evolving gold landscape and regulatory environment. We are planning to take inputs from all stakeholders. This is a global initiative and we are engaging with the government representatives, market participants and others to understand their concerns and expectations and meet the needs of stakeholders and that of consumers," he added.

NTPC exploring two nuclear power units of 1,400 MW in Banka, Bihar

NEW DELHI: As part of its energy diversification plan, state-owned NTPC is looking to set up two nuclear units of 700 MW each in the Banka district of Bihar, which could entail an investment of around Rs 25,000 crore.

At present, NTPC officials are conducting a feasibility study for two 700-MW nuclear units in the district, located around 250 km from Patna, a government official said.

The Bihar government has also assured full support for the project & water availability. Initial estimates suggest that around 1,000 acres of land would be required for these units, the official said without sharing any financial information.



tion. According to industry estimates, a 1 GW nuclear plant requires an investment of Rs 15,000-20,000 crore and typically takes at least three years from concept to commissioning.

A detailed project report (DPR) will be prepared after the feasibility report is completed, he said. NTPC is looking to set up around 30 GW of company-owned nuclear projects across various locations in the country in line with the government's

ambition of having 100 GW nuclear capacity by 2047.

The power PSU is eyeing at least 2 GW of nuclear capacity as early as 2032.

NTPC is also setting up a nuclear project in a joint venture (JV) with Nuclear Power Corporation of India Ltd (NPCIL) in Rajasthan at an investment of about Rs 42,000 crore.

The company, with an installed capacity of over 89,615 MW at the group level, has accelerated its nuclear plans, with recent legislative changes aimed at attracting investment in this space. NTPC Ltd has steadily expanded and diversified into new energy sources, spanning coal, gas/liquid fuel, hydro and solar power.

'India following diversified strategy to boost exports to China, cut import dependence'

India's exports to China rose about 37 per cent to \$19.47 billion in 2025-26 from \$14.25 billion in 2024-25. The exports stood at \$0.71 billion in 1997-98

NEW DELHI: India is following a diversified strategy to boost exports to China by strengthening domestic capacities while reducing import dependence through diversification of its supplier base, as complete decoupling from Beijing is difficult since Chinese inputs support the country's industrial growth, a senior official said.

"While India may not have hard decoupling from China, it is creating its own capacity both in terms of having resilient supply chain and also in terms of increasing our own exports capacity," the official

said.

The senior government official added that India primarily imports raw materials, intermediate and capital goods, such as auto components, electronic parts and assemblies, mobile phone components, machinery and related parts, and active pharmaceutical ingredients (APIs), which are used to produce finished goods for export and support domestic manufacturing.

"Whatever China is supplying is the backbone of India's production. Some consumer durables are also coming but are less in numbers," the official



cial said. India's exports to China rose about 37 per cent to \$19.47 billion in 2025-26 from \$14.25 billion in 2024-25. The exports stood at \$0.71 billion in 1997-98.

On the other hand, imports from Beijing increased 16 per cent to \$131.63 billion in

CLOSER LOOK

- » Imports from Beijing jumped 16% to \$131.63 billion in 2025-26 from \$113.44 billion in 2024-25
- » The trade deficit has risen from \$99.2 billion in 2024-25 to \$112.6 billion in 2025-26. Imports were just \$1.11 billion in 1997-98

2025-26 from \$113.44 billion in 2024-25. The trade deficit has risen from \$99.2 billion in 2024-25 to \$112.6 billion in 2025-26. Imports were just \$1.11 billion in 1997-98.

The main export sectors where India has recorded health growth in exports dur-

ing the last fiscal year include printed circuit boards, electrical appliances, telephone systems, shrimp, aluminium ingots, black tiger shrimp, vessels, and certain agri commodities.

However, there is a need to further widen the export bas-

ket to increase India's share in China's imports.

The import surge is in electronics, electrical machinery, pharmaceuticals ingredients, APIs, auto parts, telecom instruments, industrial machinery, computer hardware peripherals, organic chemicals, accumulator and batteries, plastic raw materials, residual chemicals, and bulk drugs.

"These all goods are ultimately going into our industrial process, as we are industrialising, imports will increase naturally," the official added. The government is taking a series of measures to boost domestic

manufacturing and the production-linked incentive scheme is a key step in that direction. The boost in manufacturing going ahead will help cut imports and increase exports.

The scheme is helping domestic businesses to create value chains and for that the industry needs capital goods and intermediate parts.

Further, to reduce import dependence on China, the government is in the process of identifying goods that are China-intensive and cost-competitive, and is examining whether Indian companies can source them from coun-

tries such as Taiwan, South Korea, Japan, and the European Union.

An Inter-Ministerial Committee (IMC) is there to monitor exports and imports regularly and it takes corrective measures in consultation with various stakeholders.

The composition of the IMC includes representatives from Department of Commerce, Department of Revenue, Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade, Directorate General of Foreign Trade and Directorate General of Commercial Intelligence and Statistics.

AI-LED PRODUCTIVITY IS CAUSING REVENUE DEFLATION IN LEGACY SERVICES

Top-5 Indian IT cos post mixed FY26 amid macro headwinds

OUR CORRESPONDENT

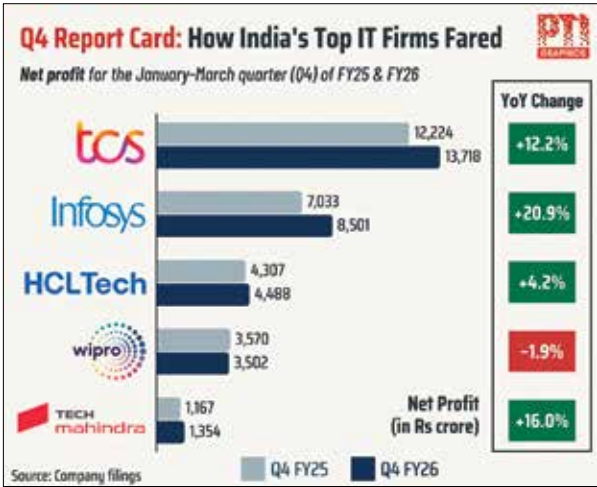
NEW DELHI: India's top five IT majors — TCS, Infosys, HCLTech, Wipro, and Tech Mahindra — closed FY26 at a critical inflection point, navigating a structural reset driven by macroeconomic headwinds, West Asian geopolitical risks, and the dual-edged sword of Artificial Intelligence (AI).

Earnings analyses reveal a sector transitioning rapidly away from traditional effort-based delivery. AI-driven productivity is causing revenue deflation in legacy services.

However, this near-term compression is being offset by a multi-billion-dollar surge in new AI-native engagements, prompting a decisive shift in client priorities from sheer scale to modular, outcome-driven contracts.

This paradigm shift is starkly reflected in mixed FY27 outlooks and evolving talent metrics. While TCS and Infosys signalled that the worst macro headwinds are receding, peers like HCLTech and Wipro flagged continued volatility and soft discretionary spending. "AI may cause about 2-3 per cent annual deflation in traditional IT services revenues for the next couple of years. Indian IT services could see an incremental AI-led TAM of \$300-400 billion by 2030," an ICICI Direct report said.

The country's largest IT services firm reported a 12.22 per



'Artificial Intelligence may cause about 2-3% annual deflation in traditional IT services revenues for next couple of years'

cent jump in its March quarter net profit to Rs 13,718 crore. Its revenue for Q4 jumped 9.64 per cent to Rs 70,698 crore. For FY26, profit after tax increased 1.35 per cent to Rs 49,210 crore, while revenue grew 4.58 per cent to Rs 2.67 lakh crore.

Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) noted that the company is entering the new fiscal year with positive momentum, asserting that the bulk of recent headwinds are mostly behind them. Its annualised AI services revenue crossed \$2.3 billion, which is over 6 per cent of its overall revenue. TCS CEO K Krithivasan said TCS is entering

the new fiscal year with positive momentum on the back of new deal signings and asserted that a bulk of the headwinds it had experienced in the recent past are mostly behind. He said the impact of the West Asia crisis will be limited to the challenges faced by clients in the travel and transportation segment and those based in the Gulf region.

Infosys reported a 20.8 per cent rise in consolidated net profit to Rs 8,501 crore in the Q4 FY26, while revenue from operations increased 13.4 per cent to Rs 46,402 crore. For FY26, net profit climbed 10.20 per cent to Rs 29,440 crore, and

Key Points

» Earnings analyses reveal a sector transitioning rapidly away from traditional effort-based delivery

» While TCS and Infosys signalled that the worst macro headwinds are receding, peers like HCLTech and Wipro flagged continued volatility and soft discretionary spending

» Tata Consultancy Services annualised AI services revenue crossed \$2.3 billion, which is over 6 per cent of its overall revenue

revenue rose 9.6 per cent to Rs 178,650 crore. The management acknowledged that AI is beginning to cannibalise traditional IT services but noted that this deflation is being offset by a surge in new AI-driven services.

HCLTech reported a 4.2 per cent rise in consolidated net profit to Rs 4,488 crore in Q4 FY26, with revenue rising 12.34 per cent to Rs 33,981 crore. For FY26, the firm recorded a net profit of Rs 16,642 crore (4.30 per cent decline) & revenue of Rs 130,144 crore (11.18 per cent rise).

The management flagged a highly volatile demand environ-

ment shadowed by tariffs and softened discretionary spending, giving FY27 growth guidance of 1-4 per cent in constant currency. The company noted that AI is causing a deflation of 2-3 per cent per year in traditional segments, though its Advanced AI revenue reached \$155 million in Q4. HCLTech CEO C Vijayakumar termed the year as one of an uncertain demand environment.

On the West Asia crisis, HCLTech said the company's exposure to the Middle East is very limited, with the region contributing only about 1 per cent to the revenues.

Wipro reported a consolidated net profit of Rs 3,501.8 crore for Q4 FY26, down 1.89 per cent year-on-year, while revenue rose 7.6 per cent to Rs 24,236.3 crore. For FY26, net profit saw a marginal 0.47 per cent increase to Rs 13,197.4 crore, with revenue standing at Rs 92,624 crore. It described the current macroeconomic environment as the "new normal", marked by geopolitical & policy disruptions. The company's board also approved a mega Rs 15,000 crore share repurchase programme.

Tech Mahindra reported a 16 per cent growth in consolidated net profit to Rs 1,353.8 crore for Q4 FY26, with revenue rising 12.6 per cent to Rs 15,076.1 crore. For FY26, profit climbed 13.15 per cent to Rs 4,810.9 crore & revenue rose 7.2 per cent to Rs 56,815.4 crore.

PSBs asked to complete wage revision process in 12 months

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government has asked public sector banks to initiate the process of negotiations for the 13th Bipartite settlement in a time-bound manner and finalise it in the next 12 months.

The wage revision for employees and officers of public sector banks would be due from November 1, 2027.

Public sector banks (PSBs) and financial institutions, including insurance companies revise wages of their employees every five years.

As part of the settlement, the Indian Banks' Association (IBA) is expected to engage in dialogues with the employees' unions/associations and arrive at a mutually agreeable wage settlement.

As the timely conclusion of the settlements is essential for maintaining industrial harmony, the Department of Financial Services advised Public Sector Banks (PSBs) in a communication to their heads to initiate the necessary measures to commence negotiations for the impending wage revision.

Public Sector Banks are advised to complete the negotiation process within a maximum period of 12 months, the communication dated April 20 said.

Just before the last settlement process, the finance ministry had asked IBA to ensure that all future wage negotiations should be finalised before the beginning of the subsequent period so that the wage revision could be implemented from the due date itself.



Public sector banks (PSBs) and financial institutions, including insurance companies revise wages of their employees every five years

It has been observed that on previous occasions, consequential amendments to the permanent regulations have been effected after a considerable delay following the settlement, it said.

"As negotiations for the upcoming settlement are now being initiated in a timely manner, it is underscored that the consequential amendments to relevant regulations should also be completed prior to scheduled date of the next wage settlement," it said.

It is a known fact that the banking sector is the backbone of the Indian economy and healthy and adequate compensation keeps morale of employees high.

Public sector banks have generated record profits in FY25 and is expected to continue the momentum in FY26.

Combined PSB profits

Highlights

- » The wage revision for employees & officers of PSBs would be due from November 1, 2027
- » Combined PSB profits crossed Rs 1 lakh crore to reach Rs 1.05 lakh crore in FY23, before rising to Rs 1.41 lakh crore in FY24, and to Rs 1.78 lakh crore in FY25
- » PSBs' Gross NPAs stood at record low of 2.30% at end of September 2025, while net NPAs were around 3%

crossed Rs 1 lakh crore to reach Rs 1.05 lakh crore in FY23, before rising to Rs 1.41 lakh crore in FY24, and to Rs 1.78 lakh crore in FY25.

The improvement has been driven by stronger asset quality, sustained credit growth, comfortable capital buffers and rising return on assets.

PSBs' balance sheets continue to show improvement. Gross non-performing assets stood at a record low of 2.30 per cent at the end of September 2025, while net NPAs were around 3 per cent.

The provisioning coverage ratio improved to 94.63 per cent, and the capital adequacy ratio remained healthy at 15.96 per cent at the end of the first half of FY26.

Wage settlement talks normally benefit employees of public sector banks, old generation private banks and some foreign banks.

'Gold & silver may witness selling as US-Iran peace talks loom'

NEW DELHI: Gold and silver may face some selling pressure this holiday-shortened week as traders track peace talks between the US and Iran, crude oil rates and the Federal Reserve's policy decision, analysts said.

Domestic commodity markets would remain closed on Friday for Maharashtra Day.

On the macroeconomic front, traders will monitor monetary policy decisions from the US Federal Reserve, Bank of Japan, Bank of England and European Central Bank.

Besides this, key US data on housing, Personal Consumption Expenditures (PCE) inflation and consumer confidence, along with factory activity numbers from major economies later in the week, will also guide sentiment, he added.

On MCX, gold futures dropped Rs 1,910, or 1.23 per cent, to close the week at Rs 1.54 lakh per 10 grams, while silver plunged Rs 12,506, or 4.9 per cent, to settle at Rs 2.44 lakh/kg.

According to analysts, gold's downside in the domestic market was limited by a weaker rupee.

In global markets, Comex gold fell \$138.7, or 2.8 per cent to close the week at \$4,740.9 per ounce & silver declined \$5.4, or 6.6 per cent to \$76.41 per ounce. PTI

'West Asia situation, crude oil prices & earnings to drive mkts this week'

NEW DELHI: The geopolitical situation in West Asia, particularly developments around the Strait of Hormuz, Q4 earnings from corporates and crude oil prices are the major factors to drive sentiments in the stock market in a holiday-shortened week ahead, analysts said.

Stock markets would remain closed on Friday for Maharashtra Day.

The standoff in the Strait of Hormuz has kept crude oil prices higher, reinforcing inflation concerns.

The US Fed interest rate decision would also be keenly tracked by investors.

Hariprasad K, Research Analyst and Founder, Livelong Wealth, said, "The continued escalation in West Asia, particularly around the Strait of Hormuz, and the breakdown of US-Iran negotiations have



introduced a significant event risk premium into global markets. This uncertainty is directly feeding into crude oil prices, with Brent hovering near \$107 per barrel.

"For India, this remains the single most critical macro variable, as elevated oil prices not only pressure inflation and the rupee but also weigh on corporate profitability across sectors."

From a corporate standpoint, the week is heavy on earnings, which will drive stock-specific action, he said.

Key results include UltraTech Cement, Coal India, Varun Beverages on April 27, Maruti Suzuki on April 28, Bajaj Finance and Adani Power on April 29, and a packed Thursday featuring Hindustan Unilever, Adani Ports, Adani Enterprises, and Bajaj Finserv, Santosh Meena, Head of Research at Swastika Investmart Ltd, said.

Last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex tanked 1,829.33 points or 2.33 per cent, and the NSE Nifty dropped 455.6 points, or 1.87 per cent.

"Global developments continued to dominate market direction, with ongoing uncertainty around the West Asia crisis and concerns over supply disruptions keeping crude oil prices elevated," Ajit Mishra – SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said. PTI

COAI seeks lower Trai-recommended spectrum auction price and moots idea of free radiowaves

NEW DELHI: Ahead of the next spectrum auction, the telecom industry body COAI has urged the government to lower bid prices, saying service providers have yet to recover their huge investments in 5G infrastructure, according to an official.

Speaking on the sidelines of the recently held COAI Digi-com Summit, Cellular Operators Association of India (COAI) Director General S P Kochhar said that the industry expects the government to consider the humongous investment made by telecom operators in 5G, without any return

on investment. "I hope that the spectrum prices go down because 5G has seen a lot of capital infusion without ROI. Till the time we start getting ROI, investing in a very expensive spectrum will have to be judged as a cost-effective business purpose. A spectrum cannot be just used by picking it up from the auction, but it has to be made usable with large investments," Kochhar said.

The Trai in February recommended that the government put the entire 11,790 MHz of available spectrum in the frequency bands of 600 MHz, 800

MHz, 900 MHz, 1800 MHz, 2100 MHz, 2300 MHz, 2500 MHz, 3300 MHz and 26 GHz for auction.

Spectrum with low frequency count provide wider coverage. The government is exploring auctioning spectrum in the 600 MHz band, which is expected to improve mobile network coverage inside buildings.

The regulator's recommended base price values the entire spectrum at Rs 2.1 lakh crore. The recommended price is estimated to be 19 per cent cheaper than prices recommended for the last auction held in 2022. Kochhar said that the

costing will decide as quantum of spectrum that telecom operators will buy.

"We want more spectrum. There are many countries where the spectrum is free, but there are obligations for that spectrum. So the model has to evolve now, with 5G having come in and 6G on the horizon. The model has to be different from the one which we are following. That is a call the government has to take," Kochhar said. The government has decided to allocate spectrum administratively without auction for satellite communication services. PTI

NEW DELHI: Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal will hold a meeting with representatives of export promotion councils and industry associations on Monday to discuss ways to boost the outbound shipments, an official said.

The meeting will be held after India and New Zealand sign the free trade pact here at Bharat Mandapam. Todd McClay, New Zealand's Minister for Trade and Investment, is here with a business delegation.

Meanwhile, both ministers held discussions with exporters in Agra on Sunday. Representatives of industries such



as leather, footwear, pharma, sports goods and light engineering were present in the meeting.

The Monday meeting is also important as Indian exporters are reeling under the impact of the West Asia crisis, triggered by the US-Israel conflict with Iran. Shipping companies are reluctant to carry goods to Middle Eastern countries, a key

export destination for Indian businesses.

Merchandise exports posted the steepest fall in five months, declining 7.44 per cent in March to \$38.92 billion due to trade uncertainty and geopolitical tensions, with shipments to West Asia contracting by more than 50 per cent.

The trade deficit, however, narrowed to nine-month low of \$20.67 billion in March on account of lower imports. Imports dipped 6.51 per cent to \$59.59 billion in March, driven by a significant decline in inbound shipments of crude oil and gold, the data showed. PTI

Peak power demand hits all-time high of 256.11 GW

NEW DELHI: India's peak power demand hit an all-time high of 256.11 GW on Saturday due to an intensifying heat wave, which increased the use of cooling devices, according to the latest power ministry data.

The peak power demand on Saturday eclipsed the previous record of 252.07 GW, hit just a day earlier on Friday, April 24, at 1548 hrs.

According to the power ministry data, peak power demand set a new high of 256.11 GW at 1538 hrs on Saturday, and it was fully met.

Experts stated that peak power demand is inching towards the power ministry's



estimate of 270 GW for this summer season, as mercury levels have begun to rise.

Temperatures in several regions have been significantly above normal — by 5 degrees Celsius or more — indicating a developing heat stress scenario across parts of the country, according to the India Meteorological Department. PTI

'Sales of affordable homes down 23% in Jan-March in top 8 cities'

Even the Rs 50 lakhs-1 crore category witnessed decline of 12% year-on-year in Jan-March 2026 across top-8 cities

NEW DELHI: Sales of affordable homes, costing less than Rs 50 lakh each, fell 23 per cent on-year in January-March to 16,273 units across the top eight cities, mainly due to lower fresh supply in this price bracket, according to Knight Frank.

Post-COVID pandemic, the demand for luxury homes has surged. Builders are attributing the lower launches in the affordable housing segment to the high cost of inputs, especially land. In its latest report, real estate consultant Knight Frank pointed out that affordable housing segment saw the steepest decline of 23 per cent

during the January-March period of this year, with all eight cities reporting a fall in sales.

As per the data, even the Rs 50 lakhs-1 crore category witnessed a decline of 12 per cent year-on-year during the first quarter of the 2026 calendar year to 23,567 units across eight major cities. These cities are Mumbai, Delhi-NCR, Pune, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Chennai, Ahmedabad and Kolkata.

However, the housing sales in the Rs 1-2 crore segment rose 10 per cent to 24,657 units during January-March. In the Rs 2-5 crore category, the housing sales rose 17 per cent to 16,075

CLOSER LOOK

- » However, the housing sales in the Rs 1-2 crore segment rose 10 per cent to 24,657 units during January-March
- » In the Rs 2-5 crore category, the housing sales rose 17 per cent to 16,075 units
- » Sales in the Rs 5-10 crore price category dipped 3 per cent to 3,338 units

units. Sales in the Rs 5-10 crore price category dipped 3 per cent to 3,338 units.

Housing sales in Rs 10-20 crore category increased 12 per cent to 738 units, while sales in Rs 20-50 crore category jumped 80 per cent to 165 units.

In homes costing more than Rs 50 crore, the sales declined 93 per cent to 12 units during the January-March period.

Overall, across all price categories, Knight Frank data showed that the housing sales fell 4 per cent annually in Jan-

uary-March to 84,827 units across the eight cities due to soft demand because of high prices and uncertainties caused by the West Asia conflict.

"Market activity remained skewed toward the higher end even as growth moderated, while volumes continue to slide in ticket sizes below Rs 10 million (1 crore)," Knight Frank said in its report.

The share of these lower segments (below Rs 1 crore) has declined to 47 per cent of the total sales, compared to 54 per cent in January-March 2025.

Shishir Bajjal, International Partner, Chairman & Managing

Director, Knight Frank India, said the moderation in residential demand follows a sustained multi-year upcycle.

"While this phase can be partly attributed to a natural consolidation after strong growth, the continued rise in prices alongside softening volumes indicates growing pressure on affordability and absorption," he said. At the same time, Bajjal said the volatile geopolitical situation has also resulted in subdued interest in residential demand. The total new supply fell 2 per cent annually to 94,855 units in January-March across the eight cities. PTI

BOTH TEAMS WERE ENDED UP AT 155

Rinku, Narine shine as KKR tide over LSG in Super Over

LUCKNOW: After Lucknow Super Giants walked with them toe-to-toe in regulation time, Kolkata Knight Riders found a familiar saviour in Sunil Narine to register a tight Super Over victory in their IPL match here on Sunday.

Both Super Giants and Knight Riders ended up at 155 when a total of 40 overs were bowled, but Narine made all the difference in the Super Over.

Conjuring his years' of experience, the spinner dismissed Nicholas Pooran and Aiden Markram to limit LSG to 1 for two, which was also the lowest score in a Super Over.

The Kolkatans did not fumble and notched up the required two runs with Rinku Singh, who also had wonderful day on the field taking four catches, fittingly fetching the winning runs.

It was Rinku's well-paced 83 not out off 51 balls that worked as the catalyst for KKR total of 155 for seven earlier.

Once the Super Giants restricted KKR to that modest total, courtesy Mohsin Khan's five-for, they had an excellent chance to register a rare home



Kolkata Knight Riders' Rinku Singh (front centre), and Rovman Powell (right), being congratulated by Lucknow Super Giants' captain Rishabh Pant and others after winning the match in a super over, in Lucknow on Sunday

victory. But the hosts slipped against a set of spot-on Kolkata bowlers on a slow black soil pitch.

The result pushed KKR to eighth on the table with five points, while LSG plummeted

to the bottom of the pile with four points.

The Super Giants have some big names in their roster — skipper Rishabh Pant, Markram, Mitchell Marsh and Pooran.

But none of them could give direction and shape to LSG's chase. nPant (42) and Markram (31) looked to be in good touch and they added 57 runs for the second wicket after the early departure of Marsh.

83

It was Rinku's well-paced 83 not out off 51 balls that worked as the catalyst for KKR total of 155 for seven earlier

But Markram fell to Cameron Green's pace-off delivery, while Pant's attempt to reverse scoop Narine, resulted in a catch to stumper Tim Seifert.

It left LSG's fate in the hands of a clutch of young domestic players like Ayush Badoni, Himmat Singh and Mukul Choudhary to see off the chase.

They whittled down the equation 17 off the last over with luck and pluck. Two successive no-balls by Kartik Tyagi reduced the equation to 12 off 5 balls.

Sudharsan masterclass powers GT past CSK after bowlers set it up

CHENNAI: Bowlers calling the shots in a format dominated by big hitters is a rarity, but that script played out at Chepauk on Sunday as Gujarat Titans exploited a bounce-friendly surface to stifle Chennai Super Kings before chasing down the target through a Sai Sudharsan masterclass to win the IPL contest by eight wickets.

If the first half belonged to the bowlers, the chase was all about calculated aggression as Sudharsan produced a shining tutorial in adapting to conditions, smashing 87 off 46 balls to anchor Titans' comfortable pursuit of 159.

The win moved Titans to fifth position from seventh with eight points.

On a pitch that had earlier demanded caution, Sudharsan showed how to blend restraint with intent, picking the right deliveries to attack while respecting the bounce on offer.

He found an able partner in skipper Shubman Gill, who made a brisk 33 off 23 balls before falling to spinner Noor Ahmad.

The Titans openers laid a solid foundation with a 58-run stand, effectively taking the game away from CSK in the Powerplay itself. Gill looked fluent, mixing elegance with aggression, but his dismissal did little to slow the visitors. Sudharsan, who had struck



Chennai: Gujarat Titans' Sai Sudharsan plays a shot during the IPL match in Chennai on Sunday

a century in the previous game against RCB, carried his sublime form forward, unleashing a range of strokes, particularly against pace to keep the scoreboard ticking at a healthy rate.

The left-hander's seven sixes underlined his dominance on a

surface where CSK's batters had struggled earlier in the day.

Jos Buttler played the perfect supporting role, remaining unbeaten on 39 off 30 balls as Titans reached 154 for 1, finishing the chase with 20 balls to spare.

Mohammedan Sporting deny SC Delhi full points with 2-2 draw

NEW DELHI: Mohammedan Sporting Club came from behind twice to secure a 2-2 draw against Sporting Club Delhi in their Indian Super League match at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium here on Sunday.

The result means Mohammedan pick up their third consecutive point, taking their tally to three from ten matches. However, they remain at the bottom of the table. SC Delhi, meanwhile, move to 10th place with nine points from as many matches.

Sporting Club Delhi began on the front foot, dominating possession and pushing Mohammedan deep into

The second half saw a more balanced contest, with Mohammedan showing greater intent in attack

their own half in the early exchanges. Their pressure paid off in the 17th minute when Mohammed Aimen drew a foul inside the penalty area by Mohammedan keeper Padam Chhetri, and Matija Babovic stepped up to calmly convert from the spot and give the hosts the lead.

The home side continued to control proceedings, with Aimen and Augustine Lalrochana orchestrating attacks, while Mohammedan struggled to build momentum going forward.

Their improvement was rewarded in the 40th minute with a moment of sharp awareness from forward Thokchom Adison Singh.

A long-lofted ball from Makan Chothe caught the defence off guard, and as goalkeeper Nora Fernandes rushed out to clear, Adison calmly took the ball past him before finishing emphatically into an open net to restore parity.

NEW DELHI: Hurting from a staggering defeat despite posting 264, Delhi Capitals have little time to recover emotionally as they face another formidable side in defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru in IPL here on Monday.

The six-wicket loss to Punjab Kings, a game in which their bowlers were dismantled in a record chase, has left DC shaken.

Placed sixth on the table, they now find themselves in a tightening playoff race where another defeat could seriously dent their chances.

Delhi's campaign so far has been defined by splen-



Royal Challengers Bengaluru's captain Rajat Patidar plays a shot during a practice session, in New Delhi on Sunday

did batting but inconsistent execution with the ball.

Their top order, led by KL Rahul, has repeatedly provided blistering starts,

while the likes of Nitish Rana and David Miller have ensured momentum is maintained through the middle overs.

However, the inability to defend even imposing totals is a concern after a moderate success while chasing totals..

Teams from:

Delhi Capitals: Axar Patel (c), K.L. Rahul, Karun Nair, David Miller, Pathum Nissanka, Sahil Parakh, Prithvi Shaw, Abhishek Porel, Tristan Stubbs, Sameer Rizvi, Ashutosh Sharma, Vipraj Nigam, Ajay Mandal, Tripurana Vijay, Madhav Tiwari, Auqib Dar, Nitish Rana, T. Natarajan, Mukesh Kumar, Dushmantha Chameera, Lungisani Ngidi, Kyle Jamieson, and Kuldeep Yadav.

Royal Challengers Bengaluru: Rajat Patidar (captain), Virat Kohli, Tim David, Jacob Bethell, Romario Shepherd, Josh Hazlewood, Nuwan Thushara, Devdutt Padikkal, Jitesh Sharma, Krunal Pandya, Rasekh Dar, Bhuvneshwar Kumar, Jordan Cox, Suyash Sharma, Venkatesh Iyer, Swapnil Singh, Jacob Duffy, Kanishk Chouhan, Abhinandan Singh, Mangesh Yadav, Phil Salt, Satvik Deswal, Vicky Ostwal, and Vihaan Malhotra.

The death bowling, in particular, has looked vulnerable under pressure -- something that opposition teams have begun to target.

FINISH ON TOP OF MEDAL TALLY

Shooting: India add two medals on final day

CAIRO: Hemant Burman won silver in the men's 50m rifle 3 positions and the pair of Zuhair Khan and Addya Katyal won bronze in the trap mixed team event as India completed the ISSF Junior Shooting World Cup on top of the table with a total of 16 medals, including five gold, six silver, and five bronze. In the first finals of the day, Burman won silver after shooting 351.7 across the three positions in the 50m 3Positions

event. The 18-year-old had qualified for the final in seventh place with a score of 578-24x and was joined by Vedant Nitin Waghmare and Rohit Kanyan in the finals, who shot 581 and 580 respectively. Rohit finished in sixth place in the final with a score of 311.9, and Vedant finished in seventh with a score of 300.5. Oleg Noskov of Kazakhstan, with a new world junior record score of 355.6, won the gold medal and Nikita Solo-

kov of Uzbekistan won bronze with a score of 341.2. The other Indians in qualification, Manvendra Singh Shekhawat (578-23x), Kushagra Singh Rajawat (576-24x), and Hithesh Srinivasan (574-26x) finished outside the top eight.

In the final event of the event, the pair of Zuhair and Addya secured the bronze medal with a final score of 19 after qualifying for the medal rounds with a qualification

score of 137. The pair, who were in the silver medal hunt after the first two series, faltered in the third series with Addya missing four of her five shots and Zuhair missing one, which pushed them down to the bronze medal places.

Bence Doeboerhegyi and Anna Nyitrai of Hungary won the gold medal with a new world junior record score of 32, while neutral athletes Ramir Nikolaev

and Kseniia Tatarinova won silver with a score of 25.

In the 50m Rifle Prone Women event, all Indians, Tejal Nathawat, Yugeshwari Bais, Anushka Thokur and Khwaish Sharma finished outside the medal places. The Indian junior athletes will now shift their focus to the ISSF Junior World Championship, the blue ribbon event in the calendar, which will be held at Suhl, Germany in June.

Sooryavanshi is my new favourite batter: Australian skipper Cummins

JAIPUR: Vaibhav Sooryavanshi has earned a "new fan" with his amazing pyrotechnics and Australian skipper Pat Cummins loves the way the 15-year-olds bats.

Sooryavanshi, Rajasthan Royals' chubby-cheeked batting sensation who has taken the cricket world by storm, scored his second IPL ton -- 103 off 37 balls -- albeit it came in a losing cause against the Cummins-led Sunrisers Hyderabad.

"Yeah, I think he's my new favourite player. He hits the ball so hard, it's great to watch. It's good fun," Cummins, the World Test Championship and T20 World Cup-winning Aus-



Vaibhav Sooryavanshi

tralian skipper said after SRH's five-wicket win against Royals on Saturday.

Cummins is impressed with the kind of start Sooryavanshi has had to his career.

"You've got to be right on the money as a bowler, because if you're not, it's going a long

way. So he's impressive. Yeah, he's had a great start to his career and yeah, I love the way he plays," Cummins said.

While there has been a raging debate about the flat tracks on offer with batters easily hitting fast bowlers and spinners through the line, Cummins feels that it is fine as long as such pitches are on offer in T20s and Test matches.

"Look, maybe, I think it's just the way it is. The wickets might be flat, but it's only 20 overs, you know, so it's not a Test match where it's flat and they've had a bat for five days, so I'm okay with that. It's a maximum of four overs. Yeah, it's fine. It is what it is."

Al-Ahli beat Machida Zelvia to retain AFC Champions League Elite title

The victory took an extra-time goal from Saudi's striker Firas Al-Burikan

JEDDAH: Al-Ahli of Saudi Arabia successfully defended the AFC Champions League Elite crown after beating first-time finalist Machida Zelvia of Japan 1-0 on Saturday.

It took an extra-time goal from Saudi international striker Firas Al-Burikan to settle a bad-tempered final in front of 60,000 mainly Al-Ahli fans in Jeddah.

Al-Ahli played with 10 men for almost an hour but Machida was unable to make the advantage count.

"It's amazing," said Al-Ahli winger Riyad Mahrez, who won the UEFA Champions League with Manchester City in 2023. "It was difficult for us again. We like to make it difficult for ourselves. Ten against 11 is nearly impossible, I don't know how we found the strength and the energy. ... After the red card we stuck together, we fought more, we ran more until we scored."

There were few scoring opportunities in the first half although Al-Ahli, owned by Saudi Arabia's Public Investment Fund, should have taken the lead when Brazilian



Al-Ahli players celebrate with the trophy of after defeating Machida Zelvia in the AFC Champions League Elite football match at King Abdullah Sports City Stadium, in Jeddah

winger Galeno broke free of the Machida defense only to see his low shot saved by goalkeeper Kosei Tani. Just before the break, Merih Demiral's close-range effort was blocked on the line. Al-Ahli was reduced

to 10 men midway through the second half when Zakaria Hawasawi was sent off for head-butting Tete Yangi as the two came together in front of the referee.

The dismissal shifted the

momentum. Machida forced Al-Ahli goalkeeper Edouard Mendy into several saves. Normal time ended with Al-Ahli substitute Mohammed Abdulrahman also shown a red card while on the sidelines.

Manchester City book another FA Cup final

LONDON: Manchester City is back in another FA Cup final. Arsenal is back on top of the Premier League.

City will play in a record fourth straight Cup final after surviving a scare to beat second division Southampton 2-1 at Wembley on Saturday. Nico Gonzalez's 87th-minute winner completed a comeback after going a goal down in the second half.

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NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Date: 27.04.2026

E-tender is invited under the Two-Bid System (Unpriced & Priced) for the following works:

NIT No.	Brief Description	EMD Value (₹)	Due Date & Time of Submission	Date & time of opening
CMC/BY/26-27/RS/PM/VK/5	Turnkey project for Conversion of Overhead Electrical Network into Underground along with Multi Utility Duct (MUD) System at Chandni Chowk (2 Location i.e. Esplanade Road & More Sarai Road), Delhi	₹25 Lakh	04.05.2026 14:00 HRS	04.05.2026 15:00 HRS

Cost of each Tender Document: ₹1,180/-
For details with respect to Equipment/BOM/Services, Qualifying requirements, Terms & conditions, purchase/submit of tender documents, corrigendum etc. please visit our website www.bsesdelhi.com --> BSES YAMUNA POWER LTD Head (Contracts & Materials)
Regd.Off: BSES Yamuna Power Ltd, Shakti Kiran Building, Karkardooma, Delhi-110032 | CIN: U40109DL2001PLC111525 Website: www.bsesdelhi.com TEL: 011-41247111

कार्यालय कार्यपालन यंत्री लोक निर्माण विभाग संभाग क्रमांक 1 ग्वालियर

फोन नं. 0751-2371231

ईमेल: ecp2d1gw@nic.in

निविदा विज्ञापन क्रमांक 02/टी.सी./डी-1 ग्वा./2026-27

दिनांक 17/04/2026

मध्यप्रदेश के राज्यपाल की ओर से निम्नलिखित कार्यों हेतु नवीन निविदा प्रपत्र 2.10 पर आमंत्रण की सूचना क्र. 02 ग्वालियर दिनांक 17/04/2026 द्वारा प्रचलित भवन/पथ कार्यों की दर अनुसूची दिनांक 01.01.2024/11.04.2025 पर निविदाये लो.नि.वि. से केन्द्रीयकृत पंजीकृत केन्दर श्रेणी हेतु आमंत्रित की जाती है जिसका सम्पूर्ण विवरण <http://mptenders.gov.in> पर देखा जा सकता है। विभाग तकनीकी समस्याओं के लिए जिम्मेदार नहीं होगा। एवं किसी कारणों से की जाने वाली परिवर्तन की सूचना वेबसाइट पर ही देखें पृथक से प्रकाशित नहीं की जावेगी।

स.क्र.	टेन्डर आई.डी.	कार्य का नाम	(1) टेके की अनुमानित राशि क (2) अमानित राशि	टेन्डर कार्य की राशि (रु. में)	कार्य पूर्ण करने की समयावधि	1. पंजीयन श्रेणी
1	2026_PWDRB_501512_1	विशेषांतर न्यू विभागगुड 06 (विशेष अतिथियों हेतु अतिरिक्त कक्षा निर्माण सहित) एवं विद्युतीकरण निर्माण कार्य सड़क हाउस के पास नामी रोड ग्वालियर। (डिवायिड करी)	1. 369.00 लाख 2. 369000/-	15000/- (पोर्टल चार्ज)	12 माह वर्षाकाल सहित	लो.नि.वि.में पंजीकृत केन्दर

कुल कार्य संख्या - 01 (एक)

ऑनलाइन निविदा जारी व डाउनलोड करने की आरम्भ तिथि 18/04/2026 प्रातः 10:30

ऑनलाइन निविदा दूर प्रस्तुत करने की अंतिम तिथि 04/05/2026 प्रातः 17:30

ऑनलाइन निविदा दूर खुलने की तिथि 06/05/2026 प्रातः 11:00

निविदा कार्य करार दर्शित वेबसाइट पर (Online System) ऑनलाइन पुरतान कर ही क्रय किये जा सकते हैं। तथा सम्पूर्ण जानकारी पोर्टल पर प्राप्त कर सकते हैं।

कार्यपालन यंत्री लोक निर्माण विभाग, संभाग क्र. 1 ग्वालियर (म.प्र.) फोन 07512371231

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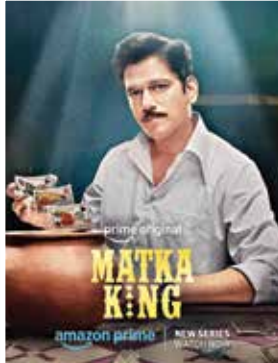
"स्वभाव स्वच्छता, संस्कार स्वच्छता"



‘Matka King’ emerges as most-watched new series in two years

It is headlined by Vijay Varma
alongside Kritika Kamra and others

It follows Brij Bhatti, an enterprising cotton trader who introduces ‘Matka’, an honest gambling system that transforms an elite pastime into a nationwide phenomenon



OUR CORRESPONDENT

Prime Video’ announced the record-breaking success of its latest ‘Prime Original’ series, ‘Matka King’, which premiered worldwide on April 17. The intense drama has emerged as the most-watched new scripted series on the service in the last two years and has been trending in the ‘Top 10’ across 37 countries since its launch. Within a week of its premiere on the service, ‘Matka King’ was trending as #1 in 17 countries worldwide. The series’ performance is a testament to Prime Video’s position as the preferred home for rooted and authentic stories that resonate deeply with audiences both in India and globally. “At ‘Prime Video’, we remain committed to championing stories that reflect diverse slices of

India, while still being universally relatable. The phenomenal success of ‘Matka King’ exemplifies this vision,” said Nikhil Madhok, director and head of ‘Originals’, Prime Video, India. “The series trended in ‘Top 10’ across 37 countries, including #1 in 17 countries in the first week of its launch. Set against the backdrop of 1960s Bombay, its compelling narrative has clearly connected with audiences and highlights the growing scale and global appeal of Indian storytelling. Vijay Varma’s performance as Brij Bhatti has been simply outstanding, creating a memorable character that joins Prime

Video’s cult icons such as Kalleen Bhैया, Srikant Tiwari and Hathiram Chaudhary. This response reinforces our belief that powerful stories and layered characters rooted in authenticity can transcend boundaries and connect with viewers across geographies.” Set in the fast-changing Bombay of the 1960s, ‘Matka King’ follows Brij Bhatti, an enterprising cotton trader who introduces ‘Matka’, an honest gambling system that transforms an elite pastime into a nationwide phenomenon. The series is headlined by Vijay Varma as Brij Bhatti, alongside Kritika Kamra and others in pivotal roles.

KJo’s ‘Koffee with Karan’ to return this year

He talked about ‘Kabhi Alvida Naa Kehna’ being adapted into a web series

One of the most daring films Karan Johar ever attempted was ‘Kabhi Alvida Naa Kehna’. Within the framework of mainstream commercial filmmaking, it confronted the theme of infidelity head-on, supported by a star cast led by Shah Rukh Khan, Amitabh Bachchan and Rani Mukerji. Upon release, the film received a mixed response from both critics and audiences. However, over time, it has come to be seen as one of the more fascinating works in Karan’s filmography, often revisited for the questions it raises about relationships, morality and emotional truth. Recently, while speaking at ‘The Week’, Karan revealed that he is now adapting the film into a long-form series. He said, “We’re actually adapting it into a long-form series. The root of that film was, of course, released in 2006 to very polarised responses. I had many people come up to me and ask me whether I was unwell after that film, because they said, ‘How can you endorse infidelity?’ And I was like, ‘How can you endorse something that’s already so sold out?’” He further recalled an audience reaction from the film’s



early screening, saying, “I still remember when I was watching the film with an audience a day before its release.” AGENCIES

Park Chan-wook developing a Western project

LOS ANGELES: South Korean auteur Park Chan-wook, who is set to preside over the jury at the upcoming Cannes Film Festival, is also heading to the French Riviera with a major Western project featuring an impressive ensemble cast. According to ‘Deadline’, the film is titled ‘The Brigands of Rattlecreek’ and brings together Oscar winner Matthew McConaughey, Oscar nominee Austin Butler and Pedro Pascal. Chinese star Tang Wei, who starred in the filmmaker’s critically acclaimed 2022 title ‘Decision to Leave’, is also on board the project. Written by S Craig Zahler, the screenplay has long been a passion project for Park, who did revisions on the most recent draft. The story follows a sheriff and a doctor who seek revenge against a group of bandits

‘The Brigands of Rattlecreek’ brings together Oscar winner Matthew McConaughey, Austin Butler and Pedro Pascal

who exploit a torrential thunderstorm to rob and terrorise the occupants of a small town. The project will explore themes central to Park’s body of work - vengeance, retribution, the consequences of violence and the power of memory and family - transplanted to the American West. Bradley Fischer and Park produced the film for Moho Film with Jisun Back, Mike Medavoy and Georgia Kacandes serving as executive producers. Park Chan-wook has been keen to make the ‘Black List’ script for over a decade. PTI



AN EVENING OF FESTIVE MOMENTS

MPOST

The Embassy of the Kingdom of the Netherlands hosted King’s Day, celebrating King Willem-Alexander’s 59th birthday at the Netherlands Residence on the evening of April 23 in New Delhi. The Union Minister of State (Independent Charge), Dr Jitendra Singh, was welcomed by Ambassador Marisa Gerards and Peter Knoope and graced the occasion. The event brought together diplomats, policy makers, Dutch citizens in India and members of India’s cultural and business communities. The venue had the spirit of Dutch Artist Van Gogh from ‘Starry Nights’ to ‘Sunflowers’. Guests were dressed in orange,



The Embassy of the Kingdom of the Netherlands hosted King’s Day, celebrating King Willem-Alexander’s 59th birthday at the Netherlands Residence

the colour of Dutch pride and the atmosphere was festive. Ambassador Gerards said, “Today, on the occasion of His Majesty’s 59th birthday, we are celebrating more than a national occasion; we are celebrating the spirit of our peoples. It is the day the Neth-

erlands turns orange, when music is everywhere and people’s creativity and enterprise bring communities to life.” “King’s Day is a wonderful reminder of the Netherlands’ vibrant, inclusive society where people from different backgrounds come together to

share ideas and drive innovation. This diversity makes our economy stronger, our culture richer,” she added. The reception in New Delhi highlighted Dutch culture and the growing ties between India and the Netherlands in diplomacy, culture and business.



Nicolas Cage is Spider-Noir in the new trailer

It’s a live-action series based on the ‘Marvel’ comic ‘Spider-Man Noir’



OUR CORRESPONDENT

Prime Video’ unveiled the official trailer for ‘Spider-Noir’, the highly anticipated new series starring Nicolas Cage in his first leading TV role. Produced by ‘Sony Pictures Television’, the new series will roll out globally on ‘Prime Video’ on May 27, 2026. For the first time ever, viewers can choose their own adventure as the series will be available to stream in two ways, in ‘Authentic Black & White’ and ‘True-Hue Full Color’.

The official trailer made its world premiere to a packed room filled with 2100 fans at Centro Banamex Convention Center in Mexico City for CCXPMX26, the largest pop culture festival in the world. Lamorne Morris, Li Jun Li, Jack Huston, Karen Rodriguez, alongside creator/co-showrunner/executive producer Oren Uziel, took the stage to introduce the series to audience goers. The panel also debuted an extended scene, offering attendees an immersive first look into the world, tone and stakes of ‘Spider-Noir’ with a special video greeting from Nicolas Cage. Fans at the convention also had the opportunity to collect five different badges inspired by the iconic characters from the new series and designed by Mexican artist Jorge Molina.

‘Spider-Noir’ is a live-action series based on the ‘Marvel’ comic ‘Spider-Man Noir’. It tells the story of Ben Reilly (Nicolas Cage), a seasoned, down on his luck private investigator in 1930s New York, who is forced to grapple with his past life, following a deeply personal tragedy, as the city’s one and only superhero. Full cast includes Nicolas Cage, Lamorne Morris, Li Jun Li, Abraham Popoola, Karen Rodriguez, with Jack Huston and Brendan Gleeson.

Anupam Kher praises Michael Jackson’s biopic

The veteran actor said that the film turned out to be ‘phenomenal’, ‘inspiring’ and ‘deeply moving’



Anupam Kher lauded Michael Jackson’s biopic ‘Michael’ and said the film turned out to be ‘phenomenal’, ‘inspiring’ and ‘deeply moving’. The film, released on April 24, is directed by Antoine Fuqua and features Jackson’s nephew, Jaafar Jackson. It chronicles the life of Jackson, from his childhood with the ‘Jackson 5’ (an American pop group formed in 1964 in Gary, Indiana, by brothers Jackie, Tito, Jermaine, Marlon and Michael Jackson) to his 1980s ‘Bad’ tour. The project has received mixed reviews from the audience and critics. Kher shared a video on his ‘X’ handle as he reviewed the film. “‘MICHAEL’ IS MAGIC:

Last night I watched the biopic #Michael on the one and only Michael Jackson. Phenomenal. Inspiring. Deeply moving. I must confess, I don’t understand English music as much as I understand emotions. But with Michael Jackson, language was never a barrier. Just like Charlie Chaplin, he spoke directly to the heart. And the heart understands everything,” he wrote. The actor said he felt grateful to have watched a film on such an artist, adding that there will never be another Michael Jackson. “What stayed with me was not just the music or the performances... but the journey. A life. And life is never perfect. It has its ups and downs,

its struggles and its shadows. But if a life can inspire millions across generations, across countries, across languages... then it is nothing short of magical. Sometimes I feel critics forget that. They judge moments, not journeys. And journeys are messy, beautiful, unpredictable... just like life itself,” he wrote. “I came out of the film feeling grateful. Grateful that such artists exist. Grateful that we get to witness their brilliance. There will never be another Michael Jackson. And maybe that’s the point. And #JaafarJackson as Michael is unbelievably AMAZING and OUTSTANDING,” he added. Jackson has several tracks to his credit, including ‘Billie Jean’, ‘Beat It’ and ‘Thriller’, among others. He died due to acute propofol intoxication in 2009 in Los Angeles. He was 50. The film was announced in 2023 and is produced by ‘Lionsgate’ and ‘GK Films’.



The film features Jackson’s nephew, Jaafar Jackson